

Portuguese, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Portuguese one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart — traced back to its root (usually Latin), then forward to the English cousins you already own. It is written for someone starting from zero, whose only shared language is English. *obrigado* (“thanks”) turns out to be English *obligated*; *tarde* (“afternoon”) is *tardy*; *noite* (“night”) is the *noct-* of *nocturnal*.

Portuguese is a daughter of Latin, and often the one that wore its words down *most*: the article *ille* eroded all the way to a single letter, *o*. Where a sister language (Spanish, French, Italian) makes a contrast vivid, the book supplies it in full — no prior knowledge of them assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Portuguese out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind pronunciation. Each lesson names the one or two sounds its own word needs, exactly where they are needed. The whole system is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Portuguese greetings, built from their pieces — a word for “good,” the day-parts, the article that carries gender, and a “thank you” that changes with *who is speaking*. Each word is taken apart to its root and its English cousins.

1.1 *olá* — “hi”

Sounds you’ll need

oh-LAH — stress on the second syllable (the written accent on *á* marks it). The *l* is clear, the *a* open.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

olá (“hi”) is a friendly interjection of uncertain birth — probably a natural call for attention (like English *hello* / *hallo*), possibly reinforced by Arabic *w-Allāh* (“by God”) during the centuries of Moorish Iberia. Unlike most Portuguese words, it has *no* clean Latin root: some greetings are just sounds. Spanish, its close sibling, has the near- identical *hola*.

Why it’s said this way

olá is friendly and fairly neutral — fine for most people, though for real formality or a first meeting you add *bom dia* / *boa tarde*, built next. In Brazil you’ll also hear *oi* for a casual “hi.”

1.2 *bom* / *boa* — “good”

Sounds you’ll need

bom is **nasal** — *bõ*, the *m* not fully closed, the vowel sent through the nose. **boa** (feminine) is a clear *BOH-ah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bom / **boa** (“good”) ← Latin *bonus* / *bona* → English **bonus**, **bonanza**. Spanish, another daughter of Latin, made *bueno* / *buena*; Portuguese wore *bonus* down further, to the little nasal *bom*.

Grammar Lens

bom / **boa** **agrees** with its noun: *bom* (m.), *boa* (f.), *bons* / *boas* (pl.) — Latin’s adjective agreement, alive across the Romance family. So it’s *bom dia* (m.) but *boa tarde* (f.).

1.3 *o* / *a* — “the,” and an article worn to a single letter

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

o (masculine “the”) and **a** (feminine) ← Latin *ille* / *illa* (“that one”). Here Portuguese did something striking: it wore the word down *further than any of its sisters* — Latin *ille* → Italian *il* → Spanish *el* → Portuguese just **o**. The whole demonstrative has eroded to a single vowel. (English “the” is Germanic, unrelated.)

Grammar Lens

Every Portuguese noun is **masculine or feminine** — Latin’s genders collapsed to two. Learn each noun *with* its article: *o* for masculine, *a* for feminine. Beware the trap coming next: *o dia* (“the day”) is *masculine* even though it ends in *-a*.

1.4 *dia* — “day”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

o dia (masc.) ← Latin *dies* (“day”) — taken almost straight, like Spanish *dia*. Cousins straight from *dies*: **di**urnal, **di**ary; and, through the derived *diurnum*, English **j**ournal and **j**ourney (which is why Italian *giorno* and French *jour* look so different — they took the longer road).

Grammar Lens

A gender trap. *dia* ends in *-a* — the usual feminine signal — yet it is *masculine*: *o dia*. This is a fossil of its Latin origin (*dies* was masculine), and a reminder to learn each noun *with* its article rather than guessing gender from the ending.

1.5 *bom dia* — “good day / good morning,” assembled

bom (“good”) + *dia* (“day”) = **bom dia**, “good day” — and, in practice, “good morning”: it’s the greeting until noon.

Why it’s said this way

bom dia is the polite, all-purpose morning hello — safe with anyone. After midday it gives way to *boa tarde*, and after dark to *boa noite*. (Spanish pluralises the blessing — *buenos días* — where Portuguese keeps it singular, *bom dia*.)

1.6 *tarde* — “afternoon,” and *boa tarde*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

a tarde (fem.) ← Latin *tardus* (“slow, late”) — the same *tardus* behind English **tard**y and **retard** (“to slow”). Portuguese named the afternoon after its *lateness*, exactly as Spanish did with the identical *tarde*. **boa tarde** = “good afternoon.”

1.7 *noite* — “night,” and *boa noite*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

a noite (fem.) ← Latin *noctem* (*noct-*) → English **nocturnal**, **equinox**. Portuguese turned the Latin *-ct-* into **-it-** (*noite*) — the same change French made (*nuit*), while Spanish went *-ch-* (*noche*) and Italian *-tt-* (*notte*).

Latin	Portuguese	Spanish	French	Italian
<i>noctem</i>	<i>noite</i>	<i>noche</i>	<i>nuit</i>	<i>notte</i>
<i>factum</i>	<i>feito</i>	<i>hecho</i>	<i>fait</i>	<i>fatto</i>

boa noite = “good night” — used both as an evening greeting and as the farewell for bed.

1.8 *obrigado* / *obrigada* — “thank you,” i.e. “[I am] obliged”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

obrigado / **obrigada** (“thanks”) ← Latin *obligātus* (“bound, obliged”), from *ob-* (“to”) + *ligāre* (“to bind”). It is the *same* word as English **obligated**, and shares its root with **oblige**, **obligation**, and (via *ligare*) **ligament** and **liable**. To say *obrigado* is to say “I am *bound* to you” — indebted by your kindness.

Grammar Lens

It agrees with the speaker, not the listener. Because *obrigado* literally means “[I am] obliged,” it takes the gender of *whoever is speaking*: a man says **obrigado**, a woman says **obrigada** — no matter who they’re thanking. This is unlike the ordinary Romance adjective (which matches the noun); here the adjective matches *you*.

1.9 The day of greetings

Portuguese	English
<i>olá</i>	hi
<i>bom dia</i>	good morning
<i>boa tarde</i>	good afternoon
<i>boa noite</i>	good night
<i>obrigado / obrigada</i>	thank you

Every piece traced: *bom* (*bonus*), *dia* (*dies*), *tarde* (*tardus*, “late”; English *tardy*), *noite* (*noctem*, -ct→-it-), *obrigado* (*obligātus*, “obliged”). And two Portuguese habits: the article eroded to a single vowel (*o* / *a*), and “thank you” agrees with the *speaker* (*obrigado* / *obrigada*). Next chapter: introducing yourself — *o meu nome é...* / *chamo-me...* — and Portuguese’s *tu* vs. *você* (familiar / polite “you”).

Chapter 2

How Are You?

By the end of this chapter: I can ask a Portuguese speaker how they are, casually or respectfully, and answer for myself.

The full Chapter 2 exchange: greet, ask Tudo bem?, answer for yourself, and hand the question back. PT-C02-formal-practice then rebuilds the same exchange for respect (Como está o senhor?), so the chapter's canDo covers both registers.

2.1 de nada — “you’re welcome,” or “it was nothing”

You already say **obrigado** / **obrigada** (“I am obliged”). The reply that closes the exchange is **de nada** — “of nothing” — the very same phrase, word for word, as Spanish.

Sounds you’ll need

- **final-a-reduces** — **de nada** $\approx$ *dee NAH-duh*: unstressed final *-a* softens toward *uh*; the *d* is soft.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **de** = “of / from” (Latin **dē**).
- **nada** = “nothing” — and it has the same buried story as its Spanish twin.

nada comes from Latin (**rēs**) **nāta**, “a born thing” — from *nāscī*, “to be born” (English **native**, **nature**, **natal**, re-**nais-sance**). Latin *nōn* ...

rēs nāta, “not a single born thing,” wore down until the “born thing” word, **nada**, came to mean **nothing** by itself.

Portuguese and Spanish inherited the identical word and the identical courtesy:

language	“you’re welcome”	the “nothing” word
Portuguese	<i>de nada</i>	<i>nada</i> ← <i>nāta</i> , “a born thing”
Spanish	<i>de nada</i>	<i>nada</i> ← <i>nāta</i> , “a born thing”
French	<i>de rien</i>	<i>rien</i> ← <i>rem</i> , “a thing”

So Iberia says “of no *born-thing*”; France says “of no *thing*.” Same shrug of the shoulders, one Latin idea.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “obrigado / obrigada” ... “de nada” — the full exchange
- “de nada” then English “native, nature” — nada’s true family

Before you move on

What did *nada* originally mean in Latin? (A *born thing* — *nāta*.) Which language shares *de nada* exactly, and which uses *de rien* instead? (Spanish; French.) Next: **como**, “how.”

2.2 como — “how,” the fourth *quomodo* cousin

One of two everyday ways to ask *how are you?* in Portuguese starts with **como**, “how.” It’s the same word you’ve met (or will meet) across the Romance family.

Sounds you’ll need

- **final-o-is-u** — **como** = *KOH-moo*: the final unstressed *-o* is said like *u*. (Portuguese does this to nearly every final *-o*: *obrigado* → *-doo*.)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

como = “how / like / as.” Root: Latin **quōmodo**, “in what manner” — *quō* (“in what way”) + *modo* (“manner”). It is the **same source** as its siblings:

- Spanish **cómo**, Italian **come**, French **comment** — all “how.”
- Doubling as “like/as,” it matches Spanish *como*, Italian *come*.

Notice Portuguese and Spanish look almost identical here — *como* vs *cómo* — the only visible difference is the Spanish written accent that marks the *question*. Portuguese leans on context and the question mark instead. The *modo* piece lives on in English **mode**, **model**, **moderate**.

Grammar Lens: the two Portuguese “how are you”s

Portuguese asks after you **two** ways, and you’ll assemble both next lesson:

- **Como vai?** — “how do you **go**?” (verb *ir*, “to go” — like French/German).
- **Como está?** — “how do you **stand/are**?” (verb *estar* — like Spanish).

Plus a third, verb-free favourite — **Tudo bem?** — coming up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “como” — *KOH-moo*
- *como* / *cómo* / *come* / *comment* — the four *quomodo* siblings
- “Como vai?” and “Como está?” — go, and stand

Before you move on

What Latin word gives *como*, and name two siblings. (*quōmodo* → *cómo*, *come*, *comment*.) What’s the only written difference between Portuguese *como* and Spanish *cómo*? (The Spanish accent that marks

a question.) Next: the word behind Portuguese’s favourite greeting — **tudo**.

2.3 tudo — “everything,” the heart of *Tudo bem?*

The most Brazilian way to greet someone doesn’t use a “you” or a “to be” at all — it just asks **Tudo bem?**, “everything well?” To own it, learn its first word: **tudo**, “everything.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **final-o-is-u** — **tudo** = *TOO-doo*: final *-o* → *u*, and the *d* is soft.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tudo = “everything, all,” from Latin **tōtus**, “*whole, entire*.” You ask whether the **whole** of someone’s life is going well — *is everything OK?* That root **tōtus** is completely at home in English:

- **total, totally, totality** — the whole amount.
- **teetotal** — “**totally**” abstaining (a playful reduplication of *total*).
- Italian **tutto**, Spanish **todo**, French **tout** — the same *tōtus* across the family (you’ll hear Spanish *todo* echoing this).

Grammar Lens: pairing it with “well”

Portuguese “well” is **bem** (← Latin *bene*, “well” — the *bene* of *benefit*, *benevolent*; cousin of Spanish *bien*, French *bien*). Put them together:

Tudo bem? = “Everything well?” → “How are you? / You OK?”

The magic: **no pronoun, no verb**. You skip the whole *ocê / tu / o senhor* tangle. That’s why *Tudo bem?* is the friendliest, safest opener in Brazilian Portuguese — and you can answer with the very same two words: **Tudo bem**. (“Everything’s well.”) Or just **Tudo bom**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tudo” — *TOO-doo*
- “Tudo bem?” — everything well?
- “tudo” then English “total, totally” — one family

Before you move on

What Latin word gives *tudo*, and its English cousins? (*tōtus* → total, totally, teetotal.) Why is *Tudo bem?* so easy to use? (No pronoun, no verb — it dodges the *você/tu/senhora* choice.) What’s Portuguese for “well”? (*bem* ← *bene*.) Next: assemble all three “how are you”s.

2.4 Tudo bem? — “everything well?”

You know **tudo**, “everything.” Add **bem**, “well,” and Portuguese gives you an everyday check-in with no verb at all.

Tudo bem? — “Everything well?” / “How are you?”

The friendly answer can be identical:

Tudo bem. — “Everything’s well.”

Because the question contains no “you” and no verb, it avoids choosing a social register. That simplicity is exactly why it is everywhere.

Grammar Lens: Add the listener only when useful

To bounce the question back, say:

Tudo bem, e você? — “All well, and you?”

Everyday **você** comes from *vossa mercê*, “your mercy.” Centuries of fast speech wore a respectful title into the ordinary pronoun “you,” much as Spanish *usted* grew from a form meaning “your grace.” For more explicit respect, Portuguese can use **o senhor** / **a senhora**, “the gentleman / the lady.”

You do not need either pronoun for the basic pair: **Tudo bem?** — **Tudo bem.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Tudo bem?”
- the answer — “Tudo bem.”
- “Tudo bem, e você?”

Twice through: “Tudo bem? — Tudo bem!”

Before you move on

What does *Tudo bem?* literally ask? (“Everything well?”) Why can it fit almost any listener? (It has **no verb and no pronoun.**) How do you bounce it back? (**E você?**) Where did *você* come from? (*Vossa mercê*, “your mercy.”) Next: two questions that do use verbs.

2.5 Como vai? / Como está? — go and stand

Tudo bem? needs no verb. **Como** (“how”) also builds two familiar metaphors.

question	literally	verb
Como vai?	“How does it go ?”	<i>ir</i> , to go
Como está?	“How do you stand ?”	<i>estar</i> , to be / stand

Vai comes from *ir*, whose Latin ancestor *īre* also sits inside English *exit* and *transit*. **Está** comes from Latin *stāre*, “to stand.”

Portuguese therefore keeps both pictures:

- the “go” family, like French and German;
- the “stand” family, like Spanish and Italian.

Italian also keeps both. You do not need those languages to speak Portuguese; the map simply makes the two metaphors memorable.

Tudo bem? remains the easiest default because it skips the verb and register choice altogether.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the verb-free question — “Tudo bem?”
- the “go” question — “Como vai?”
- the “stand” question — “Como está?”

Twice through: “Tudo bem? — Como vai? — Como está?”

Before you move on

Which question has no verb? (**Tudo bem?**) Which uses “go”? (**Como vai?**, from *ir*.) Which uses “stand”? (**Como está?**, from *estar*.) Portuguese keeps how many metaphors? (**Both.**) Next: the “more or less” answer.

2.6 mais ou menos — the “more or less” shrug

Someone asks *Tudo bem?* You’re okay-ish. The Portuguese shrug is **mais ou menos** — “more or less” — the same words, root for root, that Spanish uses.

Sounds you’ll need

- nasal-ai — **mais** $\approx$ *mais* with a nasal glide (*maish* in Brazil, the *s* a soft *sh*).
- final-o-is-u — **menos** $\approx$ *MEH-noos*; **ou** = a closed *oh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mais ou menos = literally “**more or less.**” Every piece is Latin at heart:

- **mais** = “more,” from Latin **magis** (“more”) — cousin of *major*, *master*, *maximum*, *mayor*.
- **ou** = “or,” from Latin **aut**.
- **menos** = “less,” from Latin **minus** — the very word English borrowed for *minus*, *minor*, *minimum*, *minuscule*.

So *mais ou menos* is a **word-for-word twin of Spanish *más o menos*** — Iberia’s shared shrug. (Portuguese *mais* and Spanish *más* are the same *magis*; the nasal *-ais* is just Portuguese’s accent.)

Grammar Lens: your answer ladder for *Tudo bem?*

answer	sense
Tudo bem / Tudo ótimo	all well / all great
Mais ou menos	so-so
Mais ou menos + a hand-wobble	“eh, could be better”
The five-language shrug set is now complete: Portuguese/Spanish mais/más o menos (“more or less”), Italian così così (“so, so”), French comme ci comme ça (“like this, like that”), German es geht (“it goes”).	

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mais ou menos” — with a little wobble
- answer “Tudo bem?” two ways — “Tudo bem!” / “Mais ou menos”
- Portuguese *mais ou menos* = Spanish *más o menos*, same Latin *magis/minus*

Before you move on

What does *mais ou menos* literally mean? (“More or less.”) What Latin words are *mais* and *menos* from, and their English cousins? (*magis* → major/ maximum; *minus* → minor/minus.) Which lan-

guage's shrug is its exact twin? (Spanish *más o menos*.) Next: put the whole exchange together.

2.7 Practice — Tudo bem?, start to finish

No new words. Assemble the chapter's atoms into one casual exchange before adding the formal version.

The exchange

— Olá! **Tudo bem?** — **Tudo bem, e você?** — **Mais ou menos.** — [after a small favour] Obrigado! — **De nada.**

The glue is **e você?**, “and you?”: **e** continues Latin *et*, while *você* grew from the respectful title *vossa mercê*.

What you've built: What you are retrieving

- **de nada** — “of nothing,” you're welcome;
- **tudo bem?** — the verb-free check-in;
- **como vai?** / **como está?** — “go” and “stand” alternatives;
- **mais ou menos** — “more or less,” so-so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both voices
- answer with “Tudo bem”
- answer with “Mais ou menos”

Twice through: “Tudo bem? — Tudo bem, e você?”

Before you move on

Run the casual exchange without looking. Which phrase answers a small favour? (**De nada.**) Which answer means “so-so”? (**Mais ou**

menos.) Which question is safest before choosing a register? (**Tudo bem?**) Next: rebuild the exchange with **o senhor** / **a senhora**.

2.8 Formal practice — Como está o senhor?

The casual exchange is secure. Now replace ordinary *você* with the respectful title **o senhor** or **a senhora**.

The exchange

— Bom dia. **Como está o senhor?** — **Bem, obrigado. E o senhor?** — Tudo bem.

For a woman, use **a senhora**. The words continue Latin *senior*, “older,” the same root as English **senior** and Spanish *señor*.

The verb stays **está** because the title is grammatically third person: “How is the gentleman/lady?” That respectful grammar is already packed into the phrase; do not switch it to informal second-person *estás* here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to a man — “Como está o senhor?”
- to a woman — “Como está a senhora?”
- “Bem, obrigado. E o senhor?”

Twice through: “Como está o senhor? — Bem, obrigado.”

Before you move on

Which titles mean a respectful “you”? (**O senhor** / **a senhora**.) Which verb form follows them? (**Está**, third person.) Where does *senhor* come from? (Latin *senior*, “older.”) You can now run the Chapter 2 exchange casually or formally.

Chapter 3

Introducing Yourself

By the end of this chapter: I can give my name in Portuguese, ask for someone else's, and say that it is a pleasure.

A whole first meeting: *Olá, me chamo ..., Como se chama?, prazer — then the same exchange again with o senhor and a senhora.*

3.1 eu — “I,” often dropped in Portuguese

Before introducing yourself, meet **eu** — “I.” Famous English cousin, and the same habit as its Romance sisters: Portuguese usually **leaves it out**.

Sounds you'll need

- nasal-**eu** — **eu** = *EH-oo*, a gliding vowel with a light nasal colour, one syllable.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

eu = “I,” from Latin **ego** — the same *ego* English borrowed outright:

- **ego**, **egoist**, **egocentric** — all Latin “I.”
- Romance siblings, all from *ego*: Spanish **yo**, Italian **io**, French **je**.

Grammar Lens: the dropped subject (pro-drop)

The verb ending already names the speaker, so Portuguese usually **omits** the pronoun: *chamo-me* (“I call myself”) needs no *eu* — the *-o* of *chamo* is “I.” You add **eu** for **emphasis** or **contrast**:

Eu estou bem, e você? — “I’m fine, and you?”

Spanish (*yo*) and Italian (*io*) do the same. It’s one of the first real habits of a Romance language: trust the verb ending, drop the pronoun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “eu” — *EH-oo*
- “eu” then English “ego, egoist” — the same Latin “I”
- eu / yo / io / je — four children of *ego*

Before you move on

What Latin word is *eu* from? (*Ego* — ego, egoist.) Why does Portuguese usually drop it? (The verb ending already says “I.”) When do you keep it? (Emphasis / contrast.) Next: introduce yourself — **me chamo**.

3.2 me chamo — “I call myself”

Like its Iberian and Italian sisters, Portuguese introduces you as what you **call yourself** — **me chamo** — from the very same Latin *clāmāre* that gave Spanish *me llamo* and Italian *mi chiamo*.

Sounds you’ll need

- **ch-is-sh** — Portuguese **ch** = “**sh**”: **chamo** = *SHAH-moo*. (A neat three-way split from one Latin *cl-*: Spanish *ll* = *y* (*llamo*), Italian *ch* = hard *k* (*chiamo*), Portuguese *ch* = *sh* (*chamo*).)
- **final-o-is-u** — final *-o* → *u*: *SHAH-moo*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me chamo = **me** (“myself”) + **chamo** (“I call”) → “**I call myself**.” Brazilians often say **eu me chamo**; European Portuguese prefers **chamo-me** (same words, pronoun clipped to the back) — both fine.

Then the name: *Me chamo Ana* — “I call myself Ana.”

The verb **chamar-se** (“to call oneself”) is from Latin **clāmāre**, “*to cry out, to call*” — shouting through English as **claim**, **exclaim**, **proclaim**, **clamor**. Three Romance naming verbs, one Latin call:

language	“I call myself”	<i>cl-</i> became
Portuguese	<i>me chamo</i>	<i>ch</i> (= <i>sh</i>)
Spanish	<i>me llamo</i>	<i>ll</i> (= <i>y</i>)
Italian	<i>mi chiamo</i>	<i>ch</i> (= hard <i>k</i>)

Another way to say it: *o meu nome é ...* (“my name is ...”), where **nome** ← Latin **nōmen**, “name” — the root of English **noun**, **nominal**, **nomenclature**, **nominate**. Two routes to the same introduction: the *verb* (call myself) or the *noun* (my name is).

Grammar Lens: the reflexive

chamo alone = “I call [someone]”; **me chamo** = “I call **myself**” — reflexive. The pronoun shifts with the person: **me chamo** (I) → **se chama** (he/she/você). And *eu* is dropped — the *-o* ending already says “I.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me chamo” — *muh SHAH-moo*, *ch* = *sh*
- “Me chamo ...” with your own name
- *me chamo* / *me llamo* / *mi chiamo* — one *clāmāre*, three sounds

Before you move on

What does *me chamo* literally mean, and its Latin root? (“I call myself”; *clāmāre* — claim/clamor.) How is Portuguese *ch* pronounced, vs Italian *ch*? (Portuguese *sh*; Italian hard *k*.) What’s the noun-route alternative? (*O meu nome é ...*, *nome* ← *nōmen*.) Next: ask it back — **Como se chama?**

3.3 Como se chama? — “what’s your name?”

Both pieces are yours: **como** (“how,” from your *Tudo bem?* chapter) and **chamar-se** (“to call oneself”). Portuguese, like all its sisters, asks the name with “**how**”: *how do you call yourself?*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Como se chama? = “What’s your name?” literally: “**How** do you call yourself?”

- **como** = “how” ($\leftarrow$ *quōmodo*).
- **se** = “yourself” (the reflexive; *me* $\rightarrow$ *se*).
- **chama** = “calls” (*você*/he-she form of *chamar-se*).

Portuguese register is friendly here — the everyday polite form uses **você**:

form	question
polite / neutral (<i>você</i>)	Como (você) se chama?
very formal	Como se chama o senhor / a senhora?
familiar (<i>tu</i> , more in Portugal)	Como te chamas?

The reply loops right back: *Me chamo Ana. E você?* And just like Spanish *¿cómo se llama?* and Italian *come ti chiami?*, the name is a matter of **how** you’re called — never *what*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Como se chama?” — *KOH-moo suh SHAH-mah*
- the whole loop — “Como se chama? — Me chamo ... E você?”
- *como se chama* / *cómo se llama* / *come ti chiami* — the same question, three sisters

Before you move on

What does *Como se chama?* literally ask? (“How do you call yourself?”) Which everyday pronoun does the polite form use? (*Você*.) What “how” word is it built on? (*Como* ← *quōmodo*.) Next: the warm reply — **prazer**.

3.4 **prazer** — “pleased to meet you,” i.e. “a pleasure”

Names traded, you close with **prazer** — “a pleasure.” It’s the twin of Italian *piacere*, and, like it, straight from Latin *please*.

Sounds you’ll need

- **pr-cluster** — **prazer** = *prah-ZEHR*: the *z* is a true *z*; stress the end. (The *pr-* shows a Portuguese sound-law: Latin *pl-* often became *pr-* — *placēre* → *prazer*, *plūs* → ...)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

prazer = “pleasure” (and, as a verb, “to please”), from Latin **placēre**, “to please.” On meeting someone it’s short for “[it’s] a pleasure.” That *placēre* root is deep in English — **please**, **pleasure**, **pleasant**, **complacent**, **placid** — and it names this courtesy across the family:

- Italian **piacere** — its exact twin (same *placēre*).
- Spanish **mucho gusto** — “much pleasure,” but from *gustus* (“taste”), a different root.
- French **enchanté** — a different picture again (“enchanted”).

Portuguese took *placēre*’s *pl-* to *pr-* (a regular shift — compare *branco* “white” ← Germanic *blank*, *praia* “beach” ← *plagia*), so *piacere* and *prazer* look a little different but are the very same word.

Grammar Lens: a one-word courtesy

Prazer stands alone, with a nod or handshake. Fuller forms: **muito prazer** (“much pleasure”), or **prazer em conhecê-lo/-la** (“a pleasure

to know you”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “prazer” — *prah-ZEHR*
- “prazer” then English “please, pleasure, placid” — the *placēre* root
- Portuguese *prazer* and Italian *piacere* — twins from *placēre*

Before you move on

What does *prazer* mean, and from what Latin verb? (“A pleasure,” ← *placēre*.) Its Italian twin? (*Piacere*.) What sound-shift turned *pl-* into *pr-*? (The Portuguese *placēre* → *prazer* change.) Next: put the whole introduction together.

3.5 Practice — introducing yourself in Portuguese

No new words. *eu, me chamo, como se chama, prazer* assemble into a real first meeting. This slots between your greetings (Ch. 1–2) and farewells (Ch. 4), so Portuguese now runs a whole conversation.

The exchange

Casual (*ocê*):

— Olá! **Como você se chama?** — **Me chamo** Ana. E você?
— João. **Prazer!** — Prazer!

More formal (o senhor / a senhora):

— Bom dia. **Como se chama a senhora?** — Chamo-me Ana Costa. E o senhor? — Costa. **Muito prazer.**

What you've built this chapter

- **eu** — “I” (← *ego*), usually **dropped** — the verb ending carries it.
- **me chamo / chamo-me** — “I call myself” (*chamar-se* ← *clāmāre*; *ch* = *sh*; kin of *me llamo*, *mi chiamo*). Alt: *o meu nome é* (*nome* ← *nōmen*).
- **Como se chama?** — “how do you call yourself?” (polite *você*).
- **prazer** — “a pleasure” (← *placēre*; twin of Italian *piacere*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full casual meeting, both voices
- the same formally — with *o senhor / a senhora*
- chain it all — greet, name, ask, how-are-you, goodbye: “Olá! Me chamo ... Como se chama? ... Tudo bem? ... Até logo!”

Twice through: Run a whole first meeting start to finish.

Before you move on

Why does Portuguese usually drop *eu*? (The verb ending says who.) What does *me chamo* literally mean, and its root? (“I call myself”; *clāmāre*.) What does *prazer* mean, and its Italian twin? (“A pleasure”; *piacere*.) Portuguese now runs greet → introduce → how-are-you → goodbye, end to end — the loop is closed.

Chapter 4

Farewells

By the end of this chapter: I can close a Portuguese conversation and pick the goodbye that matches when I will next see the person.

Open with Olá, ask Tudo bem?, then choose the exit — até logo, até amanhã, até breve, or adeus, to God, for the one that means for good.

4.1 adeus — “goodbye,” i.e. “to God”

You can greet, ask *tudo bem?*, and reply. Now close the conversation. The Portuguese goodbye is **adeus** — and it’s a tiny prayer: “**to God.**”

Sounds you’ll need

- **nasal-eu** — **adeus** $\approx$ *ah-DEH-oosh*: the *eu* is a gliding vowel; final *-s* is a soft *sh* in Portugal (*-s* $\rightarrow$ *ss* in Brazil). Stress the *-deus*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

adeus = **a** (“to”) + **Deus** (“God”), from Latin **ad Deum**, “*to God.*” It’s the fossil of a blessing — “[*I commend you*] *to God*” — said at parting, exactly like the English **goodbye**, which is a worn-down “*God be with ye.*”

This is one of the most beautiful family resemblances anywhere — five languages, one farewell prayer:

language	goodbye	=
Portuguese	<i>adeus</i>	a + Deus
Spanish	<i>adiós</i>	a + Dios
French	<i>adieu</i>	à + Dieu
Italian	<i>addio</i>	a + Dio
English	<i>goodbye</i>	“God be with ye”

The *Deus* here is the same one in English **deity**, **divine**, **adieu**, and Spanish *Dios*. When you say *adeus*, you’re handing someone to God for safekeeping until next time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “adeus” — *ah-DEH-oosh*
- *adeus* / *adiós* / *adieu* / *addio* — one “to God” across four languages
- even English “goodbye” = “God be with ye”

Before you move on

What does *adeus* literally mean, and from what? (“To God,” ← *ad Deum*.) Name two sister-language goodbyes with the same “to God” origin. (*adiós*, *adieu*, *addio*.) What English goodbye hides “God be with ye”? (*Goodbye*.) Next: the softer “see you” goodbyes — starting with **até logo**.

4.2 até logo — “see you later,” and a word straight from Arabic

The everyday Portuguese goodbye isn’t *adeus* (that’s a bit final) — it’s **até logo**, “until soon.” And its first word carries the same surprise Spanish’s *hasta* does: it came from **Arabic**.

Sounds you’ll need

- **até** = *ah-TEH*, stress the end (the accent on *é*).

- final-o-is-u — **logo** = *LOH-goo*, final -o → u.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **até** = “until, up to.” Like Spanish **hasta**, it comes from **Arabic** *ḥattā* (حتى), “until” — carried into Iberian speech across the **800 years of al-Andalus**. Both Iberian languages borrowed the *same* Arabic word for this everyday preposition. That’s remarkable: languages freely borrow *nouns* (Portuguese has thousands from Arabic — *almofada*, *açúcar*, *azeite*), but a **function word** like “until” almost never crosses. *até* and *hasta* are twin survivors of that deep Arabic layer under Iberian Romance.
- **logo** = “soon, right away, then,” from Latin **locō**, “in [that] place” → “on the spot” → “soon.” (Spanish did the identical thing: **luego** ← *locō*, and *hasta luego* is the word-for-word twin of *até logo*.)

So **até logo** = “until soon” — the exact mirror of Spanish **hasta luego**, Arabic preposition and all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “até logo” — *ah-TEH LOH-goo*
- Portuguese *até* and Spanish *hasta* — both from Arabic *ḥattā*
- *até logo* = *hasta luego*, twin for twin

Before you move on

Where does *até* come from, and which Spanish word is its twin? (Arabic *ḥattā* — Spanish *hasta*.) Why is borrowing it surprising? (It’s a *function word*; languages rarely borrow those.) What does *logo* share with Spanish *luego*? (Both ← Latin *locō*, “in place” → “soon”.) Next: **até amanhã**.

4.3 até amanhã — “see you tomorrow”

Same frame — *até* + a “when.” **Até amanhã** means “until tomorrow.” Its second word is the Portuguese cousin of a Spanish word you already know, wearing a heavy nasal ending.

Sounds you’ll need

- **nasal-anha** — **amanhã** = *ah-mah-NYÁ*: the **nh** is the *ny* of “canyon” (Portuguese spells the *ñ* sound as *nh*), and the final **-ã** is a strong **nasal a** — air through the nose, no hard consonant. Stress the end.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **até** = “until” (← Arabic *ḥattā*, from the last lesson).
- **amanhã** = “tomorrow,” from Latin **ad māneāna**, “to the morning [hour].”

That **māne** (“morning”) root is shared right across Romance — you’ve now met three of its children:

- Portuguese **amanhã** (“tomorrow”) ← *ad māneāna*.
- Spanish **mañana** — morning *and* tomorrow (the *ñ* spelled with the tilde).
- Italian **domani** (“tomorrow”) ← *dē māne*.

Same idea everywhere: tomorrow is “**the morning to come.**” Portuguese writes the *ny* sound as **nh** (*amanhã*), where Spanish uses **ñ** (*mañana*) — two spellings, one sound, both from that doubled-*n*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “até amanhã” — *ah-TEH ah-mah-NYÁ*, nasal ending
- amanhã / mañana / domani — three children of *māne*, “morning”
- Portuguese *nh* = Spanish *ñ* = the *ny* sound

Before you move on

What does *amanhã* come from, and literally mean? (*Ad m̃āneāna* — “to the morning.”) How does Portuguese spell the *ny* sound that Spanish writes as *ñ*? (As *nh*.) Next: “see you soon” — **até breve**.

4.4 até breve — “see you soon”

The last of the *até* goodbyes: **até breve**, “until soon” — literally “until [a] *short* [while].” *Breve* is a word English wears in several coats.

Sounds you’ll need

- **até breve** = *ah-TEH BREH-vee*: open *e* in *breve*, final *-e* softens toward *ee*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **até** = “until” (← Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **breve** = “short, brief,” from Latin **brevis**, “*short*.”

You already own *brevis* in English, several times over:

- **brief** — short (a *brief* meeting; a legal *brief*).
- **brevity** — shortness (“brevity is the soul of wit”).
- **abbreviate**, **abridge** — to make short.
- even the musical **breve** and the little **breve** mark [˘] over a short vowel.

So *até breve* is “**until** [a] **short** [while]” — see you before long. It’s a touch warmer and less fixed than *até logo*; both mean “see you soon.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “até breve” — *ah-TEH BREH-vee*

- “breve” then English “brief, brevity, abbreviate” — one root
- the three *até* goodbyes — *até logo* / *até amanhã* / *até breve*

Before you move on

What does *breve* mean, and its English cousins? (“Short” — brief, brevity, abbreviate.) So *até breve* literally says? (“Until a short while” → see you soon.) Next: put the Portuguese goodbyes together.

4.5 Practice — saying goodbye in Portuguese

No new words. You can now greet, ask *tudo bem?*, and **close** the conversation. Run the goodbyes until the right one is automatic.

You’ll want to know: The closings

Final / formal — the “to God” goodbye:

— Foi um prazer. **Adeus!**

Everyday “see you” — pick the *até* that fits:

— **Até logo!** (see you later / soon) — **Até amanhã!** (see you tomorrow) — **Até breve!** (see you soon)

Casual chain — greet and part:

— Olá! Tudo bem? ... **Até logo!** — **Até!** (Brazilians often clip it to just “*até!*”)

What you’ve built this chapter

- **adeus** — goodbye (“to God”; the *adiós* / *adieu* / *addio* family, and English *goodbye* = “God be with ye”).
- **até logo** — see you later (*até* ← **Arabic** *hattā*, twin of Spanish *hasta*; *logo* ← *locō*, kin of *luego*). *Até logo* = *hasta luego*.
- **até amanhã** — see you tomorrow (*amanhã* ← *ad māneāna*, kin of *mañana*; the *nh* = Spanish *ñ*).

- **até breve** — see you soon (*breve* ← *brevis*, “short” — brief/brevity).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- greet, ask, and close — “Olá! Tudo bem? ... Até amanhã!”
- choose the right goodbye — leaving for good / till tomorrow / soon
- *até logo* and Spanish *hasta luego* — twins, Arabic *até/hasta* and all

Twice through: Open and close a whole tiny exchange without stopping.

Before you move on

Which Portuguese goodbye means “to God”? (*Adeus*.) Which word inside the *até* goodbyes came from Arabic, and what’s its Spanish twin? (*Até* ← *ḥattā* — Spanish *hasta*.) You can now run a Portuguese conversation start to finish — the full greet-to-goodbye arc.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

By the end of this chapter: I can build my own Portuguese sentences with -ar verbs and say what I speak, where I live and where I work.

Conjugate falar, morar and trabalhar across eu, tu and você with the pronoun dropped, then answer Você fala português? and Onde você mora? about yourself.

5.1 falar — “to speak,” and the *f* that Spanish lost

Until now you’ve assembled fixed phrases. **Falar** (“to speak”) is your first real **verb** and the model for the large **-ar** family. Its first letter also hides a beautiful contrast with Spanish.

Sounds you’ll need

- final-**r** — **falar** = *fah-LAR*, tapped final *r*. The stem is *fal-*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

falar comes from Latin **fabulārī**, “to chat, to tell tales” — from **fābula**, “a story” (→ English **fable**, **fabulous**, **confabulate**). The **same Latin verb as Spanish hablar** — but here’s the twist:

Portuguese kept the Latin *f*-; Spanish turned *f*- into *h*-. So the two “speak” verbs diverge at letter one, and the pattern runs through the whole vocabulary:

Latin (f-)	Portuguese (f-)	Spanish (h-, silent)
<i>fabulārī</i>	falar	hablar
<i>farīna</i>	farinha (flour)	harina
<i>filīus</i>	filho (son)	hijo
<i>facere</i>	fazer (to do)	hacer
<i>ferrum</i>	ferro (iron)	hierro

So when a Spanish word starts with a silent *h*, its Portuguese twin usually still has the honest Latin *f* — *hijo/filho*, *hacer/fazer*. Portuguese is the more conservative sister here.

Grammar Lens: the -ar present tense (pro-drop)

Drop **-ar** to get *fal-*, then add the endings:

person	ending	<i>falar</i> →
(eu)	-o	falo (I speak)
(tu)	-as	falas (you speak)
(você/ele/ela)	-a	fala
(nós)	-amos	falamos
(vocês/eles)	-am	falam

Like Spanish and Italian, **Portuguese drops the subject pronoun** — *falo* already says “I,” so no *eu* needed. (Portuguese joins the *drop* camp: ES, PT, IT drop; FR, DE keep.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “falar” — *fah-LAR*
- “falo, falas, fala” — no *eu* needed
- *falar* ↔ *hablar*, *filho* ↔ *hijo* — Portuguese keeps the *f*, Spanish drops it to silent *h*

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *falar* from, and which Spanish verb is its twin? (*fabulārī* — Spanish *hablar*.) What sound-law separates them? (Portuguese kept *f*; Spanish shifted *f* → *h*: *filho/hijo*.) Does Portuguese

keep or drop the pronoun? (Drops it.) Next: **morar**, “to live.”

5.2 **morar** — “to live,” i.e. to *linger* somewhere

A second **-ar** verb — and a distinctive Portuguese choice. Where its sisters say “live” with *habitāre* (“keep having a place”), everyday Portuguese uses **morar** — from a verb that means to **linger**.

Sounds you’ll need

- **morar** = *moh-RAR*, tapped final *r*, clean vowels.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

morar comes from Latin **morārī**, “to delay, to linger, to tarry, to stay a while.” To *dwell* somewhere is, in Portuguese, to *linger* there — a softer, more temporary image than “keeping” a place. That *morārī* root survives in English in a couple of unexpected words:

- **moratorium** — an official *delay* (a pause on payments or actions).
- **demur** — to *linger* / *hesitate*, to raise an objection (*without demur*).

(Portuguese does also have *habitar* — the *habitāre* verb its sisters use — but it’s formal; **morar** is what you actually say: *Onde você mora?*, “Where do you live?”)

Grammar Lens: same -ar template

| (eu) moro · (tu) moras · (você) mora | (-o / -as / -a) |
| moramos · moram | |

Moro em Lisboa. — “I live in Lisbon.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “morar” — *moh-RAR*
- “moro, moras, mora”
- “Onde você mora?” — “Where do you live?”; “morar” ↔ *moratorium*

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *morar* from, and what did it mean? (*morārī* — “to delay / linger.”) English cousins? (*Moratorium*, *demur*.) Say “I live in Lisbon.” (*Moro em Lisboa*.) Next: **trabalhar**, “to work.”

5.3 trabalhar — “to work,” and the torture returns

A third **-ar** verb — and Portuguese rejoins its Iberian sister on one of the darkest etymologies anywhere. **trabalhar** (“to work”), like Spanish *trabajar*, began as a word for **torture**.

Sounds you’ll need

- nasal-anha — the **-lh-** is a *ly* glide (as in Spanish *ll*):
trabalhar = *tra-ba-LYAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

trabalhar comes from Vulgar Latin **tripaliāre**, “to torture” — from **tripalium**, a Roman instrument of torture made of **three stakes** (*tri* — “three” + *pālus* “stake” → English *pale*, *impale*). *Torture* → *toil* → *work*, and English took the same road: **travail** (painful effort) → **travel** (a journey was an ordeal).

So Portuguese and Spanish are **twins** here — *trabalhar* and *trabajar*, both from *tripaliāre*. Only the middle consonant differs: Latin *-li-* became Portuguese **-lh-** (*trabalhar*) and Spanish **-j-** (*trabajar*). And this puts the “work” verbs of the five languages into two neat camps:

- **Torture** (*tripalium*): Portuguese *trabalhar*, Spanish *trabajar*, French *travailler*.
- **Labour** (*labor*): Italian *lavorare*.

Three languages remember work as *torture*; only Italy remembers it as *labour*.

Grammar Lens: same -ar template

| (eu) trabalho · (tu) trabalhas · (você) trabalha | (-o / -as / -a) |

Trabalho no Porto. — “I work in Porto.”**Your turn**

Say these aloud:

- “trabalhar” — *tra-ba-LYAR*
- “trabalho, trabalhas, trabalha”
- trabalhar ↔ trabajar (twins) → travail → travel — torture to journey

Before you move on

What did *traballar* originally mean, and from what device? (“To torture,” ← *tripalium*, three stakes.) Its Spanish twin, and the one difference? (*trabajar*; Latin *-li-* → PT *-lh-* / ES *-j-*.) Which language uses “labour” instead? (Italian, *lavorare*.) Next: your first sentence — **Falo português.**

5.4 Falo português — your first real sentence

The payoff: you take a **verb** you conjugated and a **noun**, and build a sentence no one handed you — *Falo português*, “I speak Portuguese.” (*Falo* covers both “I speak” and “I’m speaking.”)

You’ll want to know: The new word: português

português = “Portuguese,” from **Portus Cale** — a Roman-era port at the mouth of the **Douro** river (today’s **Porto** / **Oporto**). *Portus* is Latin “port, harbour” (→ English **port**, **portal**, **import**); **Cale** is older and debated — perhaps Celtic for “harbour/shelter,” or Latin *cālidus* “warm.” So *Portugal* began as a single **harbour town**, whose name spread to the whole country and its language. Say it *por-too-**GESH*** (final *-s* = *sh* in Portugal).

You'll want to know: The sentence, assembled

Falo (I speak, from *falar*) + **português** = **Falo português**.

A complete, grammatical Portuguese sentence. As before:

- **No *eu*.** The *-o* of *falo* says “I” — Portuguese drops the pronoun (like Spanish and Italian).
- **No article** on the language: *falo português*.

With this, **all five languages** you’ve been building now cross the same line — from reciting phrases to **making sentences**:

	“I speak/learn [language]”
Spanish	Hablo español
Portuguese	Falo português
Italian	Parlo italiano
French	Je parle français
German	Ich lerne Deutsch

Swap the pieces: **Moro em Lisboa. · Trabalho no Porto. · Você fala português?**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Falo português” — *FAH-loo por-too-GESH*
- drop the *eu* — Portuguese doesn’t need it
- “português” ← *Portus Cale*, a single harbour town that named a nation

Before you move on

Where does *português* come from? (*Portus Cale*, a port at the Douro’s mouth → Porto.) In *Falo português*, why no *eu* and no article? (The *-o* is “I”; languages take no article.) Which three of the five languages drop the pronoun? (Spanish, Portuguese, Italian.) Next: practice.

5.5 Practice — making sentences with -ar verbs

For the first time you're **building** Portuguese sentences from a pattern. Drill the three verbs until the endings are automatic — and remember, Portuguese drops the *eu*.

Your turn: conjugate on command

Run each through *eu* / *tu* / *ocê* (pronoun dropped in speech):

- **falar**: falo · falas · fala
- **morar**: moro · moras · mora
- **trabalhar**: trabalho · trabalhas · trabalha

Same endings every time (-o / -as / -a), no pronoun needed.

Your turn: say something real

— **Você fala** português? — **Falo** um pouco. E você? — Também. **Onde** você **mora**? — **Moro** em Lisboa, e **trabalho** no Porto. — Obrigado! — De nada.

What you've built this chapter

- **the regular -ar present tense** — drop *-ar*, add *-o/-as/-a/-amos/-am*; pronoun **dropped** (like Spanish, Italian).
- **falar** (← *fabulārī* → fable; twin of Spanish *hablar* but with the *f* kept), **morar** (← *morārī* “to linger” → moratorium — a root no sibling uses), **trabalhar** (← *tripalium* “torture”; twin of *trabajar*).
- **Falo português** (← *Portus Cale*, a harbour town) — first self-assembled sentence, and the **fifth language** to cross from phrases into sentences.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- conjugate all three verbs, *eu/tu/ocê* — no pronoun spoken

- answer about yourself — what you speak, where you live, where you work
- chain it — “Olá! Falo português. Você fala português? ... Até logo!”

Twice through: “Você fala português? — Falo um pouco.”

Before you move on

What are the three singular *-ar* endings? (*-o* / *-as* / *-a*.) Give the “I” forms of the three verbs. (*Falo, moro, trabalho.*) *falar* vs Spanish *hablar* — what’s the sound-law difference? (Portuguese kept *f*-; Spanish shifted *f*→*h*.) Portuguese now moves in real sentences — this book has handed over rules, not phrases.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Ten

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one to ten in Portuguese and hear the old numbers still sitting inside setembro and dezembro.

Count *um* to *dez*, pair *sete*, *oito*, *nove* and *dez* with *setembro*, *outubro*, *novembro* and *dezembro*, and hear Latin's *-ct-* become the *-it-* of *oito*, *noite* and *leite*.

6.1 um, dois, três, quatro, cinco — counting to five

Portuguese counts almost like its sister Spanish — but with two signature Portuguese twists: heavy **nasal vowels**, and a number that still **changes for gender** where Spanish long stopped. Spanish twins are beside each.

Sounds you'll need

- **nasal-um** — **um** is nasal: *oong* said softly through the nose, no real *m*. (The *-m* is just the spelling for nasality, as in *sim*, *bom*.)
- **open-e** — **três** = *trehs* with an open *e* and the circumflex marking it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Portuguese	← Latin	Spanish twin	English cousins
um (1)	<i>ūnus</i>	<i>uno</i>	unit, union, unique (and <i>a/an, one</i>)
dois (2)	<i>duo</i>	<i>dos</i>	duo, dual, double
três (3)	<i>trēs</i>	<i>tres</i>	trio, triple, triangle
quatro (4)	<i>quattuor</i>	<i>cuatro</i>	quart, quarter, quadrant
cinco (5)	<i>quīnque</i>	<i>cinco</i>	quintet, quintessence

Cinco is spelled **identically** to Spanish — the two closest sisters. But watch *two*.

Grammar Lens: um/uma and the gendered “two” (dois/duas)

um is also “a/an,” gendered **um** (masc.) / **uma** (fem.): *um café, uma cerveja*. That much matches Spanish. The surprise is **two**: Portuguese still inflects it — **dois** (masc.) / **duas** (fem.) — a direct survival of Latin *duo* (masc.) / *duae* (fem.). So it’s *dois cafés* but *duas cervejas*. Spanish levelled this to a single *dos* centuries ago; Portuguese kept the old split. The rest (*três, quatro, cinco*) don’t change.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “um, dois, três, quatro, cinco” — count up
- the gendered two — “dois cafés” (masc.) / “duas cervejas” (fem.)
- each with its English cousin — “dois/duo, três/trio, cinco/quintet”

Before you move on

Give 1–5 in Portuguese. (*Um, dois, três, quatro, cinco.*) Which number still changes for gender, and how? (*Two — dois / duas*, ← Latin *duo/duae*.) What does *um/uma* mean besides “one”? (“A/an.”) Next: **6–10**, where a Portuguese sound-shift is on full display.

6.2 seis, sete, oito, nove, dez — and the calendar’s secret

The rest of the way to ten. Like Spanish, Portuguese hides the calendar fact — **setembro–dezembro are Latin for 7, 8, 9, 10** — and one number, *oito*, puts a signature Portuguese sound-shift on full display.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-oi — **oito** = *OY-too*, **dois** rhymes with it: the *oi* glide.
- **dez** = *dehs* (open *e*); the final *-z* is a soft “sh”/“s” in Portugal, “s” in Brazil.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Portuguese	← Latin	Spanish twin	English cousins
seis (6)	<i>sex</i>	<i>seis</i>	sextet , sextant
sete (7)	<i>septem</i>	<i>siete</i>	setembro (the 7th month!), septet
oito (8)	<i>octō</i>	<i>ocho</i>	outubro (8th), octave , octopus
nove (9)	<i>novem</i>	<i>nueve</i>	novembro (9th), novena
dez (10)	<i>decem</i>	<i>diez</i>	dezembro (10th), decimal , dízimo

The star is **oito**. Latin *octō* had a *-ct-* cluster, and Portuguese turned every Latin *-ct-* into **-it-**: *octō* → *oito*, *noctem* → *noite* (“night”), *lactem* → *leite* (“milk”), *factum* → *feito* (“done”). So *oito*, *noite*, and *leite* all carry the same fingerprint — once you spot the *-it-*, you can often guess the Latin word had a *-ct-*. (Spanish took a different path: *octō* → *ocho*, with *-ct-* → *-ch-*. Same cluster, two sisters, two solutions — *oito* vs *ocho*.)

Grammar Lens: why the months are “off by two”

Setembro means “7th,” yet sits **9th**. The old **Roman year began in March**, so *September* really was the seventh; *julho* and *agosto* (July, August) were inserted later and shoved the counting months down. The Latin numbers stuck to the month names. Every *dezembro*, you’re saying Roman “**ten**” — and *dez* also gave Portuguese *dízimo*, a “tithe” (a tenth), the twin of English *dime*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “seis, sete, oito, nove, dez” — finish the count

- “sete/setembro, oito/outubro, nove/novembro, dez/dezembro”
- the *-ct-* → *-it-* set — “oito, noite, leite” — then Spanish “ocho”

Before you move on

Give 6–10 in Portuguese. (*Seis, sete, oito, nove, dez.*) What Latin cluster became *-it-* in *oito*, and one more example? (*-ct-*; *noite* ← *noctem* / *leite* ← *lactem*.) Why is *dezembro* Latin for “ten”? (The Roman year began in March.) Next chapter builds on this toward time and days.

Chapter 7

Days of the Week

***By the end of this chapter:** I can name all seven Portuguese days and count the weekdays from domingo the way Portuguese does.*

Run domingo, segunda, terça, quarta, quinta, sexta, sábado, and explain why Monday is the second day: domingo, the Lord's day, is counted first.

7.1 segunda to sexta — the week that got numbered

Here Portuguese does something **no other Romance language does**. French, Italian, and Spanish all name their weekdays for planet-gods (*lundi, lunedì, lunes* = the Moon). Portuguese threw the pagan gods out and **numbered** the days instead — and the numbers are the very ones you just learned.

Why it's said this way

In the 6th century, **Martinho de Braga**, a bishop in what is now northern Portugal, refused to let Christians name days after *Mars* and *Jupiter*. Borrowing the Church's word for the numbered holy days of Easter week, he called them **feiras** — and Portuguese alone kept the system for **every** week.

feira ← Latin **fēria**, “a feast-day / a day free of work.” (The same *fēria* drifted, elsewhere, into “market/fair” — English **fair** is its cousin, because markets were held on feast-days.)

Grammar Lens: The pattern: [ordinal] + feira

Portuguese	means	← ordinal of	(cardinal you learned)
segunda -feira (Mon)	“2nd feast-day”	<i>secundus</i> “second”	<i>dois</i> (2)
terça -feira (Tue)	“3rd”	<i>tertius</i> “third”	<i>três</i> (3)
quarta -feira (Wed)	“4th”	<i>quartus</i> “fourth”	<i>quatro</i> (4)
quinta -feira (Thu)	“5th”	<i>quintus</i> “fifth”	<i>cinco</i> (5)
sexta -feira (Fri)	“6th”	<i>sextus</i> “sixth”	<i>seis</i> (6)

So *quarta-feira* is literally “**fourth** feast-day,” and you can hear *quatro* (4) inside *quarta*. In everyday speech the “-feira” is often dropped: “*Até segunda!*” — “See you Monday!” (Why does Monday start at **two**, not one? Because Sunday is counted as the *first* day — the next lesson closes that loop.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “segunda, terça, quarta, quinta, sexta” — Monday through Friday
- hear the number in each — “quarta ← quatro (4), quinta ← cinco (5), sexta ← seis (6)”
- drop the tail — “Até sexta!” (“See you Friday!”)

Before you move on

How is Portuguese unique among Romance languages here? (It **numbers** its weekdays — *feiras* — instead of naming planet-gods.) What does *feira* mean, and its English cousin? (“Feast-day,” ← *fēria*; English *fair*.) What number hides in *quinta-feira*? (Five — *quinta* ← *quintus*, cousin of *cinco*.) Next: the two days that **kept** their old names — *sábado* and *domingo*.

7.2 sábado and domingo — and why Monday is “the second”

Five weekdays got numbered — but two kept their names. *Sábado* and *domingo* are the **religious anchors** of the Portuguese week, and *domingo* is the key that explains why the counting started where it did.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Portuguese	← Latin	meaning	shared with
sábado	<i>Sabbatum</i> ← Hebrew <i>shabbāt</i>	the “ Sabbath ,” rest-day	Spanish <i>sábado</i> , Italian <i>sabato</i> , French <i>samedi</i>
domingo	(<i>diēs</i>) <i>Dominica</i> ← <i>Dominus</i>	“the Lord’s day”	Spanish <i>domingo</i> , Italian <i>domenica</i>

- **sábado** is the **Sabbath**, from Hebrew *shabbāt* “to rest” — the one weekend name every Romance language shares (even numbering-mad Portuguese kept it).
- **domingo** is “the **Lord’s** day,” *diēs Dominica*, from *Dominus* “lord, master” (→ English *dominion*, *dominate*, *dame*).

Grammar Lens: domingo is “day one” — so Monday is “day two”

Now the loop closes. The Church counted **domingo (Sunday)** as the **first day** of the week — *prima feria*, the Lord’s day, the start. That’s why:

domingo = 1st → **segunda-feira** (Monday) = **2nd** → terça (3rd) → ... → sexta (Friday) = 6th → sábado (Saturday) = 7th.

Monday isn’t the first weekday in this system — it’s the day **after** the Lord’s day, the *second*. So *segunda-feira* (“second feast-day”) makes perfect sense once you know Sunday was counted first. The whole week is a countdown anchored on *domingo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full week — “domingo, segunda, terça, quarta, quinta, sexta, sábado”
- the anchors — “sábado = Sabbath, domingo = the Lord’s day”
- the logic — “domingo is 1st, so segunda (Monday) is 2nd”

Before you move on

Give all seven Portuguese days. (*Domingo, segunda ... sábado.*) What does *domingo* mean, and why does that make Monday “*segunda*”? (“The **Lord’s** day”; Sunday is counted **first**, so Monday is the **second**.) Which weekend name do all the Romance languages share? (*Sábado* — the Sabbath.) Next chapter builds on this toward telling the time.

Chapter 8

Telling Time

By the end of this chapter: I can tell the time in Portuguese and use *meio-dia* and *meia-noite* for the two hours that take no number.

Say meio-dia and meia-noite, split each into meio or meia plus dia or noite, and catch noctem → noite as the same shift that gave oito.

8.1 hora — the hour, said in full

Portuguese “hour” is **hora**, from Latin **hōra** (← Greek *hōrā*) — the same word behind Spanish *hora*, French *heure*, and English *hour*. And unlike Italian, which hides the word, Portuguese keeps **horas** right out loud.

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — the **h** of *hora* is silent (as everywhere in Portuguese): say *OH-ra*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hora ← Latin **hōra** ← Greek **hōrā**, “a time of day.” Portuguese kept the Latin spelling’s silent *h*-, exactly as English *hour* does. Line the sisters up: *hora* / *hora* / *heure* / *Uhr* / *hour* — one Roman word (itself Greek-born) fanned across five languages.

Grammar Lens: “é uma hora” but “são duas horas”

Portuguese states the word **horas** in full, and the verb agrees with the number:

É uma hora. — “It is one o’clock.” (singular: *é* “it is” + *uma hora*) **São duas horas.** — “It is two o’clock.” (plural: *são* “they are” + *duas horas*) **São dez horas.** — “It is ten o’clock.”

Literally “**they are** two **hours**.” Two things to notice, both from earlier chapters: the verb is **é** (one) vs **são** (two or more), like Italian *è/sono*; and **two** still shows gender — *duas horas* (feminine, agreeing with *horas*), the *dois/duas* split you met in the numbers.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hora” — *OH-ra*, silent h
- “é uma hora ... são duas horas, são três horas”
- “duas horas” — feminine *duas*, not *dois*

Before you move on

What word is *hora* from, and its Spanish twin? (Latin *hōra* ← Greek *hōrā*; Spanish *hora*.) Why “*são duas horas*” but “*é uma hora*”? (Plural takes *são*; one o’clock is singular *é*.) Why *duas* and not *dois*? (*Horas* is feminine — the *dois/duas* gender split.) Next: **meio-dia** and **meia-noite** — noon and midnight.

8.2 meio-dia and meia-noite — noon and midnight

Two named hours: **meio-dia** is noon; **meia-noite** is midnight. Each names the **middle** of the day or night, and *meia-noite* hides a sound-shift you already met in the numbers.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Both phrases begin with **meio/meia**, “half, middle.” It comes from Latin **medius/media**, cousin of English *mid*, *medium* and Spanish *medio*:

Portuguese	=	← Latin	literally
meio-dia	<i>meio</i> + <i>dia</i>	<i>medius</i> + <i>diēs</i>	“ mid-day ” (noon)
meia-noite	<i>meia</i> + <i>noite</i>	<i>media</i> + <i>noctem</i>	“ mid-night ” (midnight)

- **meio-dia** = “mid-day.” *dia* (“day”) ← *diēs*; *meio* is masculine (agreeing with the masculine *dia*).
- **meia-noite** = “mid-night.” *meia* is **feminine** (for the feminine *noite*) — the *meio/meia* gender pair, like the *dois/duas* you know. And look at **noite**: it comes from Latin **noctem**, and the *-ct-* became *-it-* — *noctem* → *noite* — the **very same ct→it shift** that turned *octō* into *oito* (“8”) in the numbers chapter. Spot *-it-* and you can often guess a Latin *-ct-* underneath.

To use them, they *are* the hour:

É meio-dia. — “It is noon.” **É meia-noite.** — “It is midnight.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “meio-dia” (noon), “meia-noite” (midnight)
- break them — “meio (middle) + dia (day)”, “meia + noite (night)”
- the shift — “noite ← noctem, like oito ← octō”

Before you move on

What do *meio-dia* and *meia-noite* literally mean? (“Mid-day” and “mid-night.”) Why *meia-noite* but *meio-dia*? (*meia* feminine for *noite*, *meio* masculine for *dia*.) What earlier sound-shift is inside *noite*? (*ct→it*: *noctem* → *noite*, like *octō* → *oito*.) Next chapter builds on this toward months and family.

Chapter 9

Months and Seasons

By the end of this chapter: I can name the Portuguese months and seasons and explain how verão grew out of a word for spring.

Give a primavera, o verão, o outono, o inverno, then trace verão back through vēranum to vēr, spring — the summer word grown out of the spring one.

9.1 os meses — the gods and numbers of the calendar

The Portuguese months are the Roman procession of gods and Caesars, worn down the Portuguese way. And two things you know pay off: *março* is the war-god, and *setembro-dezembro* are the Latin numbers 7–10.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Portuguese	← Latin	who / what	Spanish twin
janeiro	<i>Januarius</i>	Janus , god of beginnings	<i>enero</i>
fevereiro	<i>Februarius</i>	the <i>Februa</i> purification	<i>febrero</i>
março	<i>Martius</i>	Mars , the war-god	<i>marzo</i>
abril	<i>Aprilis</i>	<i>aperire</i> “to open”	<i>abril</i>
maio	<i>Maius</i>	Maia , growth-goddess	<i>mayo</i>
junho	<i>Junius</i>	Juno , queen of gods	<i>junio</i>
julho	<i>Julius</i>	Julius Caesar	<i>julio</i>
agosto	<i>Augustus</i>	emperor Augustus	<i>agosto</i>
setembro	<i>september</i>	“ 7th ” (<i>septem</i>)	<i>septiembre</i>
outubro	<i>october</i>	“ 8th ” (<i>octo</i>)	<i>octubre</i>
novembro	<i>november</i>	“ 9th ” (<i>novem</i>)	<i>noviembre</i>
dezembro	<i>december</i>	“ 10th ” (<i>decem</i>)	<i>diciembre</i>

Portuguese tells: *janeiro/fevereiro* kept the *-eiro* ending (← *-arius*, the same suffix in *feira*), and *setembro/dezembro* echo the numbers *sete/dez* you learned. Two payoffs:

- **março = Mars**. The war-god’s month, the same Mars behind English *March*.
- **setembro...dezembro = 7...10**. Still the Latin numbers, because the Roman year began in **March**; then *julho* (Julius) and *agosto* (Augustus) were inserted and pushed the count down two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “janeiro, fevereiro, março ... novembro, dezembro”
- “março = Mars, the war-god”

- “setembro = 7 (sete), dezembro = 10 (dez)”

Before you move on

Which god is *março* named for? (**Mars**, the war-god.) Why is *dezembro* Latin for “ten”? (The Roman year began in March.) Which two months honour real **people**? (*Julho* — Julius; *agosto* — Augustus.) Next: the **estações**, the seasons.

9.2 as estações — the seasons, and a shifting summer

Four seasons — and a small mystery in one of them. Portuguese’s word for **summer**, *verão*, didn’t come from a “heat” word like French *été*. It grew out of the word for **spring**. Here’s how.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Portuguese	← Latin	literally
a primavera (spring)	<i>prīma vēra</i>	“ first spring / first green ” (<i>prīma</i> + <i>ver</i> “spring”)
o verão (summer)	<i>vēranum (tempus)</i>	“the spring-like / warm season” (← <i>vēr</i> “spring”!)
o outono (autumn)	<i>autumnus</i>	“autumn” (<i>ct/tumn</i> → <i>ut</i> : <i>autumnus</i> → <i>outono</i>)
o inverno (winter)	<i>hibernum</i>	“the wintry season” (cousin of <i>hibernate</i>)

The twist is in the first two, both born from Latin **vēr**, “spring”:

- **primavera** = *prīma* + *ver*: “the **first** spring / first green” — the year’s opening season (shared with Spanish and Italian).
- **verão** ← *vēranum*, which meant “**spring-like**, of the growing season.” Warmth crept forward on the calendar, and the word slid with it — so Portuguese’s “summer” literally *grew out of* “spring.” (Spanish did the same: *verano*.)

And **outono** ← *autumnus* shows a familiar Portuguese move: the *au...t* smoothed to **ou**, the same softening you saw in *oito* and *noite*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “a primavera, o verão, o outono, o inverno”
- the twist — “verão ← veranum ← ver (spring): summer from spring”
- “inverno ~ hibernate”; “outono ← autumnus”

Before you move on

Name the four Portuguese seasons. (*Primavera, verão, outono, inverno*.) What’s surprising about *verão*’s origin? (It comes from *vēr* “**spring**” — the summer-word grew out of the spring-word.) What does *primavera* literally mean? (“**First spring / first green**.”) Next chapter builds on this toward family and food.

Chapter 10

Family

By the end of this chapter: I can name my parents and my siblings in Portuguese and say why irmão is not built on Latin's frater.

Say o pai, a mãe, o irmão, a irmã with their nasal endings, then cut frāter germānus down to germānus alone and land on irmão, twin of Spanish hermano.

10.1 o pai, a mãe — the family words worn to the bone

Every Romance sister descends from *pater* and *māter*, but **Portuguese wore them down the furthest**. Italian kept *padre/madre*; French *père/mère*; Portuguese dissolved the middle consonant entirely, leaving the one-syllable **pai** and the nasal **mãe**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **o pai** (“father”) ← Latin **pater**. Portuguese dropped the intervocalic **-t-** completely: *pater* → *pae* → *pai*. The same disappearing--*t-* you saw in Ch.1's *noite* is here taken all the way to a bare diphthong.
- **a mãe** (“mother”) ← Latin **māter**. Same loss of *-t-*, and the *a* soaked up a nasal from the lost *-n/-m-* environment → the tilde vowel **ã** (*mãe* = “mahng-ee,” nasal).

Articles: *o* pai (masculine), *a* mãe (feminine).

Grammar Lens: The plural trick — os pais

Portuguese says **os pais** for “**the parents**” — but literally it is “**the fathers**.” Like Spanish *los padres*, the masculine plural **covers a mixed group**: one father + one mother = *os pais*. (And mind the spelling twin: **o país** — with an accent — means “**the country**”; *os pais* / *os países* are a classic pair to keep straight.)

The learned adjectives, borrowed back from Latin, still show the old root: **paternal**, **maternal** — so *pai* and *paternal* are the worn-down and the dressed-up versions of the same word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “o pai, a mãe” — *mãe* fully nasal
- the erosion — “*pater* → *pae* → **pai**; the *-t-* vanished”
- “os pais = the parents (lit. ‘the fathers’); mind *o país* = country”

Before you move on

Give “father” and “mother” with articles. (**o pai, a mãe**.) What happened to the *-t-* of *pater/māter* in Portuguese? (It **vanished** — *pater* → *pae* → *pai*.) What does **os pais** mean literally and in use? (Literally “the fathers”; in use, “**the parents**.”) What word does *o país* (accented) mean? (The **country** — a spelling trap.) Next: **o irmão, a irmã** — and a surprise about where “brother” comes from.

10.2 o irmão, a irmã — the brother who isn’t a “frater”

French and Italian build “brother” from Latin *frāter* (*frère, fratello*). Portuguese — and Spanish with it — does something completely different, and it is one of the best etymologies in the whole language.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **o irmão** (“brother”) and **a irmã** (“sister”) come **not** from *frāter* but from Latin **germānus**, meaning “**genuine, of the same stock, born of the same parents.**”
- The Romans said **frāter germānus** — a “**full** brother,” one sharing both parents, as opposed to a half-brother. Over time Iberian speakers **dropped the *frāter*** and kept the adjective: (*frāter*) *germānus* → *irmão*. So a Portuguese brother is literally a “**full-blood** one.”

Articles: *o* irmão (masc.), *a* irmã (fem.); the masculine plural **os irmãos** covers a mixed set (“siblings”), exactly as *os pais* did for parents.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

That same *germānus* “of the same stock” fans out in English:

- **germane** — “relevant, closely related” (originally “having the same parents”).
- **German** — the **people-name!** The Romans called the tribes across the Rhine *Germani*, plausibly “the genuine/kindred ones.” So *irmão* (“brother”) and *German* (the nation) spring from one Latin word for **kinship**.

Spanish made the **identical** swap — *hermano* / *hermana* — so Portuguese *irmão* and Spanish *hermano* are twins, both meaning “full-blood brother,” both leaving *frāter* behind (kept only in bookish *fraternal* / *fraterno*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “o irmão, a irmã” — both nasal endings
- the origin — “*frāter germānus* → drop *frāter* → **irmão**, ‘full brother’”
- the cousins — “*germano* → *germane*, and *German* the people”

- the twin — “Portuguese *irmão* = Spanish *hermano*”

Before you move on

Give “brother” and “sister” with articles. (**o irmão, a irmã.**) What Latin word are they from — and what did it mean? (**germānus** — “genuine, of the same parents”; from *frāter germānus*, “full brother.”) Name two English cousins of *germānus*. (**germane; German,** the people-name.) What is the Spanish twin of *irmão*? (*hermano.*) Next chapter: sentences about the whole family.

Chapter 11

Bread, Water, and Wine

By the end of this chapter: I can name bread, water and wine in Portuguese and hear the -nh- of vinho as Spanish's ñ.

Say o pão, a água and o vinho, hold água against French's worn-down eau, and pronounce the palatal -nh- of vinho, already met in amanhã.

11.1 o pão — bread, worn down to a hum

o pão (“bread”) — and Portuguese does to it exactly what it did to “father.” Just as *pater* eroded to the one-syllable **pai**, Latin *pānis* wore down to the single **nasal** syllable **pão** (“**powng**”). Same word as French *pain* and Italian *pane*, taken furthest.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **o pão** (“bread”) ← Latin **pānis**. The intervocalic -n- dissolved and left its **nasality** behind on the vowel: *pānis* → *pāe* → *pão*, the tilde marking the hum — the identical process behind **pai** (← *pater*) and **mãe** (← *māter*) from the family chapter. Masculine: *o* pão; the plural is the tricky **pães**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Even worn to a hum, the root keeps its English relatives: **companion** / **company** (*com-* + *pānis*, “one you **share bread with**”), **pantry**, **pannier**. So *pão* and *companion* are the near-vanished and the well-preserved ends of one Latin word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “o pão” — fully nasal, “powng”; plural “pães”
- the parallel — “*pater* → **pai**, *pānis* → **pão** — same nasal erosion”
- “pão → companion, pantry”

Before you move on

Give “bread” with its article. (**o pão**.) What Latin word is it from, and what happened to it? (*pānis* — worn to a single **nasal** syllable, *pānis* → *pão*.) Which family word followed the *same* erosion? (**pai**, ← *pater* — and *mãe* ← *māter*.) Next: **a água** and **o vinho** — water and wine.

11.2 a água, o vinho — water and wine

Two drinks, two more sound-stories. Portuguese kept **água** close to Latin *aqua* (unlike French, which dissolved it to *eau*), and it stamps **vinho** with its signature spelling — the **-nh-**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **a água** (“water”) ← Latin **aqua**. Portuguese held its body — *aqua* → *água* — where French wore it down to a single vowel (*eau*). The accent on **á** marks the stress. It’s **feminine**: *a água*. English kept the loud original in **aquatic**, **aquarium**, **aqueduct**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **o vinho** (“wine”) ← Latin **vīnum**. The **-nh-** is Portuguese’s palatal *ny* sound — the **same sound** as Spanish **ñ** (*viño* → *vinho*), French/Italian **gn**, and the *nh* you already met in *amanhã* (“tomorrow”). One sound, four spellings across the sisters. The word still gives English **wine**, **vine**, **vinegar**, **vintage**. Masculine: *o vinho*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “a água, o vinho” — stress the *á*; *-nh-* = palatal *ny*
- the contrast — “*aqua* → **água** (kept), French **eau** (worn away)”
- “the *nh* of *vinho* = Spanish *ñ*, met before in *amanhã*”

Before you move on

Give “water” and “wine” with articles. (**a água, o vinho.**) How does *água* compare with French *eau*, from the same *aqua*? (Portuguese **kept** the body; French wore it to a vowel.) What sound is the **-nh-** in *vinho*, and its Spanish twin? (A palatal *ny* — Spanish **ñ**.) Next chapter: asking for these at a table.

Chapter 12

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

By the end of this chapter: I can count from eleven to twenty in Portuguese and read *dezesseis* as the little sentence *ten-and-six* that it is.

Run onze to vinte, hear dez e seis inside dezesseis, and note that Portuguese breaks from the fused teens at 16, a number earlier than French or Italian.

12.1 onze → quinze — the short list

Portuguese inherited the same welded Latin teens as its sisters — but it kept **fewer of them than anyone**. Just **five**. After *quinze* (15), it starts over with a completely different, much plainer method.

Grammar Lens: The five fusions

	Portuguese	← Latin	build
11	onze	<i>ūndecim</i>	“one-ten”
12	doze	<i>duodecim</i>	“two-ten”
13	treze	<i>trēdecim</i>	“three-ten”
14	catorze	<i>quattuordecim</i>	“four-ten”
15	quinze	<i>quīndecim</i>	“five-ten”

The shared **-ze** is Latin **decem** (“ten”) worn thin — the same ten inside **dez** (10) and **dezembro** (the old 10th month, from Chapter 9). The digit sits at the front: *dois*→*do*-, *três*→*tre*-, *quatro*→*cator*-, *cinco*→*quin*-.

Note **catorze** — Portuguese kept the *c*- where Spanish says *catorce* and

French *quatorze*; three worn-down versions of one Latin *quattuordecim*.

What you’ve built: And that’s where it stops

Quinze is the **last** fused number. From **16** Portuguese does something none of its sisters do so early — the next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “onze, doze, treze, catorze, quinze”
- the ten inside — “-ze = *decem* = **dez**”
- the digit inside — “**três** → **treze**, **cinco** → **quinze**”

Before you move on

Count 11 to 15. (*Onze, doze, treze, catorze, quinze*.) What is the **-ze**? (Latin **decem**, “ten” — as in *dez, dezembro*.) How many fused teens does Portuguese keep, and is that more or fewer than its sisters? (**Five** — **fewer**; French and Italian keep six.) Next: **16**, where Portuguese starts building numbers a brand-new way.

12.2 dezesseis → vinte — built from scratch, with the “and” still showing

At **16**, Portuguese stops inheriting and starts **building**. And it does it more openly than any sister: it glues together the living words for “ten,” “and,” and the digit — and leaves the **and** right there in the middle where you can hear it.

Grammar Lens: Ten AND six

	Portuguese	build	literally
15	quinze	(fused, inherited)	“five-ten”
16	dezesseis	dez + e + seis	“ten and six”
17	dezessete	dez + e + sete	“ten and seven”
18	dezoito	dez + oito	“ten eight”
19	dezenove	dez + e + nove	“ten and nine”
20	vinte	← <i>vīgintī</i>	—

Every one begins with **dez** (“ten,” Chapter 6) and most keep **e** (“and”) — so *dezesseis* is transparently a little sentence: *ten-and-six*. (*Dezoito* swallows the *e* before the vowel of *oito*.) You already know every ingredient; nothing here needs memorising, only assembling.

What you’ve built: Portuguese breaks earliest

All three Romance sisters give up fusing partway through the teens — but Portuguese gives up **first**:

language	last fused	goes transparent at
Portuguese	<i>quinze</i> (15)	16 — <i>dezesseis</i>
French	<i>seize</i> (16)	17 — <i>dix-sept</i>
Italian	<i>sedici</i> (16)	17 — <i>diciassette</i>

One inherited Latin system, three different breaking points — and Portuguese is the boldest rebuilders. (German, by contrast, never breaks at all.)

vinte (20) ← *vīgintī*, the same root as French *vingt*, Italian *venti*, and English **vigesimal**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 15→20 — “quinze, dezesseis, dezessete, dezoito, dezenove, vinte”
- hear the sentence — “*dez e seis* — ten AND six”
- the whole run, onze to vinte

Before you move on

What does **dezesseis** literally spell out? (“**Ten and six**” — *dez* + *e* + *seis*.) At which number does Portuguese break, and how does that compare with French and Italian? (At **16** — **earlier**; they break at 17.) Why does *dezoito* have no *e*? (It’s **swallowed** before the vowel of *oito*.) Next chapter: numbers in use.

Chapter 13

Colours

By the end of this chapter: I can name black, white, red and blue in Portuguese and say why not one of the four is a plain inherited Latin colour word.

Say preto, branco, vermelho and azul, take vermelho back to vermiculus, the little worm crushed for dye, and azul back to Arabic lāzaward.

13.1 preto, branco — two blacks and a borrowed white

Portuguese does something the other Romance languages don't: it keeps **two words for black**, and the everyday one isn't the Latin one at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

word	source	use
negro	Latin <i>niger</i>	literary, formal, fixed phrases
preto	Latin <i>pressus</i> “pressed, dense”	the everyday colour word

Negro is the expected inheritance — the same *niger* that gave French *noir* and Italian *nero*. But day to day, Portuguese reaches for **preto**, from *pressus* (“pressed together, compact”). Dense → thick → **dark**: a colour named for how **packed** it is, not for its shade.

You already know *pressus*'s English children: *press*, *pressure*, *compress*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin's white, *albus*, lost here too. Portuguese says **branco**, from Germanic *blank* (“shining”) — the same loan that gave French *blanc* and Italian *bianco*, arriving with the Suevi and Visigoths who settled Iberia. Notice what Portuguese did to the shape: *blanc-* → **branc-**. The **l** → **r** swap is a Portuguese signature (compare *plaza* → **praça**, *blando* → *brando*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

word	meaning
alvorada	dawn (the sky going white)
alva	white, dawn (poetic)
<i>albumina, álbum</i>	(technical borrowings)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “preto, branco”
- “o vinho branco” — Chapter 11’s wine
- “o pão é branco” — Chapter 11’s bread
- the **l**→**r** swap — “blanc → **branco**”

Before you move on

What are Portuguese’s two blacks? (**Negro** ← *niger*, literary; and **preto** ← *pressus* “pressed/dense,” the everyday one.) Why would “pressed” mean black? (**Dense** → **thick** → **dark**.) Where does **branco** come from? (**Germanic blank**, “shining” — borrowed **into** Romance.) What sound change shows in *branco*? (**l** → **r**, as in *praça*.) Next: **vermelho**, the strangest colour word in the language.

13.2 vermelho, azul — a worm and a stone

These two are the best etymologies in the whole chapter. Portuguese named its red after an **insect** and its blue after a **rock**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Every other Romance language builds “red” on the ancient root *h₁rewd^h*- (*rouge*, *rosso*, Spanish *rojo*, and English *red*, German *rot*). Portuguese went its own way.

vermelho ← Latin *vermiculus*, “**little worm**” — the diminutive of *vermis*, “worm.”

Why? Because the finest red dye in the ancient Mediterranean came from **kermes**, a scale insect harvested off oak trees and crushed for its pigment. Dyers called the creature a “little worm,” and eventually the **dye’s name became the colour’s name**.

The same word gave English **vermilion**. And *vermis* gave English **vermin**.

Portuguese does still keep the old root — in **rubro** (literary “red”) and **ruivo** (“red-haired”) — but the everyday word for red is a bug.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

azul ← Arabic *lāzaward* ← Persian *lāžward*: **lapis lazuli**, the deep-blue stone mined for millennia in Afghanistan and ground into the most expensive pigment in the medieval world.

The initial *l*- was lost — Spanish and Portuguese ears took it for the article *l’* and dropped it — leaving *azul*. The same journey produced French **azur**, Italian **azzurro**, and English **azure**.

This is the **al-Andalus** thread again: eight centuries of Arabic in Iberia left Portuguese and Spanish thousands of words, and one of them is a basic colour.

What you’ve built: The chapter in one table

Portuguese	source
preto	Latin <i>pressus</i> “pressed”
branco	Germanic <i>blank</i> “shining”
vermelho	Latin <i>vermiculus</i> “ little worm ”
azul	Arabic <i>lāzaward</i> “ lapis lazuli ”
Not one of Portuguese’s four basic colours is a plain inherited Latin colour word.	

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vermelho, azul”
- “o vinho é vermelho... o vinho tinto” — note: **wine** is *tinto*, “dyed”
- “vermelho — vermilion — vermin”
- all four — “preto, branco, vermelho, azul”

Before you move on

What does **vermelho** literally come from? (*Vermiculus*, “little worm” — the **kermes** insect crushed for dye.) Which English word is its sibling? (**Vermilion**.) Where does **azul** come from? (**Arabic** *lāzaward*, “lapis lazuli,” via Persian — the *l-* lost as if an article.) What’s odd about all four Portuguese colours? (**None** is a plain inherited Latin colour word.) Next chapter: describing what you see.

Chapter 14

Having and Telling Your Age

By the end of this chapter: I can ask a Portuguese speaker's age and give my own, holding my years with *ter* rather than being them.

Ask Quantos anos tens?, answer Tenho vinte anos — literally I hold twenty years — and set Portuguese's simplified ano against Spanish's palatalised año.

14.1 *ter* — “to have”

Every Romance language needs a word for “have.” French and Italian took one from Latin; **Portuguese and Spanish took a different one entirely** — and it didn't originally mean “have” at all.

You'll want to know: The forms

(eu)	tenho
(tu)	tens
(ele/ela/você)	tem
(nós)	temos
(vocês/eles)	têm

Two things to watch:

- **tenho** — the **-nh-** (Portuguese's palatal *ny*, = Spanish **ñ**), already met in *vinho* (Ch. 11) and *amanhã*.

- **tem** vs **têm** — “he has” vs “**they** have”. They sound nearly alike; the **circumflex** marks the plural. An accent doing grammar, not sound.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ter ← Latin *tenēre*, “to hold” — not “to have.”

language	“to have”	← Latin
French	<i>avoir</i>	<i>habēre</i>
Italian	<i>avere</i>	<i>habēre</i>
Portuguese	ter	<i>tenēre</i> “to hold”
Spanish	tener	<i>tenēre</i> “to hold”

Portuguese *does* still have **haver** (← *habēre*) — but it got demoted to an auxiliary and to *há* (“there is”). So on the Iberian peninsula the two verbs **swapped jobs**: “hold” moved up to mean *have*, and “have” moved down to a grammar word.

English kept the *tenēre* family as borrowings: **tenant** (one who *holds* land), **retain**, **maintain**, **tenacious**, **tenure**, **contain**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tenho, tens, tem, temos, têm”
- the **-nh-** — “tenho”, like *vinho*
- “Tenho um irmão” (“I have a brother”) — Ch. 10’s family
- the hold-family — “ter · tenant · retain · tenacious”

Before you move on

What did *ter*’s Latin source mean? (***Tenēre*** — “to **hold**”.) Which other language made the same swap? (**Spanish**, *tener*.) What happened to Portuguese’s *habēre* verb? (It became **haver** — an auxiliary, and *há* “there is”.) What separates *tem* from *têm*? (The **circumflex** — singular vs plural.) Next: the question *ter* is used for that English would never use “have” for.

14.2 tenho vinte anos — holding your years

Portuguese states age with **ter**. And since *ter* came from “to hold,” the sentence is, at the root, “**I hold twenty years**” — the most physical version of this idea in any of the five languages.

You’ll want to know: The phrase

Quantos anos tens? — “How many years do you **have**?”
Tenho vinte anos. — “I **have** twenty years.”

Ser is wrong here. And **anos** can’t be dropped, unlike English “I’m twenty.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ano (“year”) ← Latin *annus* → English **annual**, **anniversary**, **annals**.
 Now compare the two Iberian sisters:

Latin	Portuguese	Spanish
<i>annus</i>	ano	año

The Latin **-nn-** went two ways: Portuguese **simplified** it to a plain *n*, Spanish **palatalized** it into **ñ**. Same word, same peninsula, two outcomes — and this is exactly where Spanish’s **ñ** came from in the first place: doubled Latin *n*.

Careful: keep *ano* distinct from *ânus*. The stress and the circumflex do the work.

Grammar Lens: Who has, who is

language		literally
Portuguese	<i>tenho vinte anos</i>	I hold ...
Spanish	<i>tengo veinte años</i>	I hold ...
French	<i>j’ai vingt ans</i>	I have ...
Italian	<i>ho venti anni</i>	I have ...
German	<i>ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt</i>	I am ...
English	<i>I am twenty</i>	I am ...

Three layers: Germanic **is** its years, French and Italian **have** them, and Iberian Romance **holds** them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Quantos anos tens?”
- “Tenho vinte anos”
- your own age, using Ch. 12’s numbers
- the sister pair — “**ano** ... **año**” — one Latin *annus*

Before you move on

Which verb does Portuguese use for age? (***Ter***, never *ser*.) Given *ter*’s root, what does the sentence literally say? (“I **hold** twenty years.”) Where does *ano* come from? (Latin ***annus***.) What did Portuguese and Spanish each do with the **-nn-**? (PT **simplified** it to *n*; ES **palatalized** it to **ñ**.) Which two languages say “I **am**” instead? (**German and English**.)

Chapter 15

The Past Portuguese Kept

By the end of this chapter: I can say in Portuguese what I did with the simple past, and avoid reading *tenho falado* as I have spoken.

*Put **falei** com ele ontem, one finished act, beside *tenho falado com ele*, repeatedly and lately, and say out loud why the compound never took the simple past's job.*

15.1 falei — the past Portuguese kept

Portuguese's everyday past tense. Its interest isn't its endings — it's that Portuguese still **has** it in daily speech, when several sisters do not.

You'll want to know: The forms

(eu)	falei
(tu)	falaste
(ele/ela/você)	falou
(nós)	falámos (Portugal) / falamos (Brazil)
(vocês/eles)	falaram

One word. No auxiliary, no participle — the verb carries the past by itself.

The *nós* form is worth a note: Portugal writes **falámos** with an accent to separate it from the present *falamos*, while Brazil writes both **falamos** and lets context decide. Same word, one accent, two spelling conventions.

falei ← Vulgar Latin perfect ***fabulāvī**, the same source as Spanish *hablé*. The Latin *-āv-* dissolved and left a **stressed final vowel** behind, which is why *falei* and *falou* end where they do.

Why it's said this way

Now the point of the chapter:

language	this tense	where it lives now
Portuguese	<i>falou</i>	everyday speech
Spanish	<i>habló</i>	everyday speech
Italian	<i>parlò</i>	south yes, north literary
German	<i>sagte</i>	retreating, standard in writing
French	<i>il parla</i>	literature only

All five inherited the same thing. French, German and northern Italy each built a compound past out of “have” and let it push the old simple past out of conversation. **Portuguese and Spanish, at the western edge of the map, didn't.**

Portuguese has all the parts to build a compound — *ter* from Chapter 14, and a participle (*falado*). It simply doesn't use them for this job. The next lesson shows what it uses them for instead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “falei, falaste, falou, falámos, falaram”
- “Ontem falei com a minha mãe” (“Yesterday I spoke with my mother”)
- “Trabalhei” — Ch. 5's verb in the past
- the five fates — “falou · habló · parlò · sagte · il parla”

Before you move on

How many words does the Portuguese past need? (**One** — no auxiliary.) Where does *falei* come from? (Vulgar Latin perfect ***fabulāvī**, like Spanish *hablé*.) Which two languages kept this tense in everyday

speech? (**Portuguese** and **Spanish**.) Which one exiled it to literature? (**French**.) Next: what Portuguese does with *ter* + participle, since it isn't this.

15.2 tenho falado — the compound that means something else

Portuguese **does** have *ter* + participle. It looks exactly like the French and Italian compound past, and it means **something different**. This is one of the most common mistakes English speakers make in Portuguese.

You'll want to know: The form

ter (conjugated) + **past participle**

infinitive	participle
falar	falado
comer	comido
partir	partido
→ tenho falado, tens falado, tem falado...	

Grammar Lens: What it actually means

Portuguese	English
falei	"I spoke" — one finished event
tenho falado	"I have been speaking" — repeatedly, lately

Tenho falado com ele does **not** mean "I have spoken to him [once]." It means "I **have been** speaking to him" — **more than once, over a recent stretch of time, and it may still be going on**.

For a single completed act, Portuguese uses the simple past from the last lesson:

Falei com ele ontem. — "I spoke with him yesterday."

Why it's said this way

French and Italian let their compound take over the plain past, so *j'ai parlé* and *ho parlato* now just mean “I spoke.”

Portuguese never did — **falei** was already occupying that slot and never left. So when Portuguese assembled the same *have* + participle machinery, there was **no vacancy**, and the construction drifted into a different job: **repeated or continuing** action.

Same parts, same era, same family. Different outcome, because of what was already in the way.

language	have + participle means
French	<i>j'ai parlé</i> — I spoke
Italian	<i>ho parlato</i> — I spoke
German	<i>ich habe gesagt</i> — I said
Portuguese	<i>tenho falado</i> — I have been speaking (repeatedly)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the contrast — “**falei** I spoke · **tenho falado** I’ve been speaking”
- “Falei com ele ontem” — one event
- “Tenho falado com ele” — repeatedly, lately
- the warning — “*tenho falado* is **not** ‘I have spoken’”

Before you move on

What does *tenho falado* mean? (“I **have been** speaking” — **repeatedly**, over a recent stretch.) What do you use for one finished act? (The simple past — **falei**.) Why doesn’t Portuguese’s compound mean “I spoke”? (Because **falei** **never vacated** that slot, so the new construction took a different job.) Which languages let their compound take over the plain past? (**French, Italian, German.**)

Chapter 16

Ser and Estar

By the end of this chapter: I can choose between *ser* and *estar* in Portuguese and change what an adjective means by switching them.

Say Ela é bonita and Ela está bonita back to back, then A sopa é boa and a sopa está boa, naming the quality against the current condition each time.

16.1 ser — “to be”

Portuguese has two verbs for “to be.” Begin with **ser**, used for identity and what something is; the choice against *estar* comes later.

You’ll want to know: Present

eu sou	nós somos
tu és	~~vós sois ~~
ele/ela/você é	eles/elas/vocês são

Tu és is live in European Portuguese. **Vós** survives mainly in northern dialect and church language; everyday “you all” is **vocês**, with **são**.

You’ll want to know: Two past rows

Preterite, the completed past from Chapter 15:

fui, foste, foi, fomos, foram

Imperfect, for background or ongoing past:

era, eras, era, éramos, eram

The three anchors **sou** — **fui** — **era** look unrelated. That is a clue that several historical pieces have been welded together, which the next lesson will unpack. For now, retrieve each row as a usable pattern.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sou, és, é, somos, são”
- “Eu sou português. Ela é médica.”
- “fui, foste, foi, fomos, foram”
- “era, éramos, eram”

Before you move on

Give the present of *ser*. (**Sou, és, é, somos, são.**) Which form goes with *vocês*? (**São.**) Give the preterite row. (**Fui, foste, foi, fomos, foram.**) Which imperfect form means “I was”? (**Era.**) Next: why those rows look so different.

16.2 ser — two verbs, three stems

Sou, era, fui, ser do not resemble one another because the modern verb preserves several older roots.

Portuguese	source
sou, és, é, somos, são	Latin <i>esse</i> , “to be”
era, éramos, eram	<i>esse</i> ’s imperfect
fui, foi, foram	<i>esse</i> ’s ancient perfect <i>fuī</i>
infinitive ser	Latin <i>sedēre</i> , “to sit”

That is **two Latin verbs** but **three stems**: *esse* was already suppletive, using both its ordinary root and the older *fuī* perfect. *Sedēre* also gave English **sedentary** and **session**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The entire preterite is shared with **ir**, “to go”:

person	ser	ir
eu	fui	fui
tu	foste	foste
ele	foi	foi
nós	fomos	fomos
eles	foram	foram

Fui professor means “I was a teacher”; **fui ao Brasil** means “I went to Brazil.” What follows disambiguates them. *Fui* already belonged to *ser*’s ancestor; **ir** borrowed the row after Latin *īre*’s own perfect wore away. Spanish made the same Iberian choice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ser ← sedēre, to sit”
- “sou / era ← esse”
- “fui professor; fui ao Brasil”

Twice through: “Two verbs, three stems; *fui* has two meanings.”

Before you move on

Which Latin verb gives the infinitive? (**Sedēre**, “sit.”) Which gives *sou* and *era*? (**Esse**.) What two verbs share *fui*? (**Ser** and **ir**.) Which borrowed it? (**Ir**.) Next: put *ser* beside *estar*.

16.3 ser vs. estar — the core choice

Chapter 2 used **Como está?** Now learn *estar*’s forms and make the basic choice between Portuguese’s two verbs for “to be.”

eu estou	nós estamos
tu estás	~~vós estais ~~
ele/ela/você está	eles/elas/vocês estão

Say **vocês estão** in ordinary speech. You may hear shortened *tou* and *tá*; recognise them, but write the full forms.

Grammar Lens: What something is; how it is

ser = what something is **estar** = its location or the condition it is in

ser	estar
Ele é médico. — He is a doctor.	Ele está doente. — He is ill.
Sou português. — I'm Portuguese.	Estou em Lisboa. — I'm in Lisbon.
A neve é branca. — Snow is white.	O café está frio. — The coffee is cold.

Identity, origin, profession, and defining qualities use **ser**. Location, health, mood, weather, and resulting conditions use **estar**.

Do not reduce this to “permanent versus temporary”: **ele está morto**, “he is dead,” uses *estar*. Death is not temporary; it is a condition someone has ended up in.

What you've built: A mnemonic, not the cause

Ser contains forms from Latin *sedēre*, “sit”; *estar* continues *stāre*, “stand.” Picture **ser** as seated in identity and **estar** as standing in a condition. The history is a memory aid, not the cause: *esse* supplied *ser*'s identity meaning, while *stāre* pulled toward place and resulting state.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estou, estás, está, estamos, estão”
- “Sou português; estou em Lisboa.”
- “Ele é médico; ele está doente.”

Before you move on

Which verb names identity? (**Ser**.) Which marks location or a resulting condition? (**Estar**.) How do you say “I’m in Lisbon”? (**Estou em Lisboa**.) Why does “he is dead” use *estar*? (It is a **resulting condition**, so permanence is not the real test.) Next: use the choice to change meaning.

16.4 é bonita / está bonita — a choice you can use

Ser and *estar* are not competing answers where one is always a mistake. With many adjectives, swapping the verb deliberately changes meaning.

with ser	with estar
Ela é bonita. — She is beautiful.	Ela está bonita. — She looks beautiful now.
A sopa é boa. — It is a good soup.	A sopa está boa. — This bowl tastes good.

Ser presents the quality as part of what the subject is. **Estar** presents the quality as the current condition or impression. Context, not a mechanical “permanent” rule, decides what you mean.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Portuguese and Spanish maintain this full two-verb choice. Italian keeps *essere* and *stare* but lets them overlap differently; French has one *être* that absorbed old *stāre* pieces. German *sein* is a separate Germanic cousin.

language	broad result
Portuguese / Spanish	two verbs, chosen by meaning
Italian	two verbs with overlap
French	one fused verb
German	one verb built from Germanic roots

The Romance rows started with the same Latin material and reorganised it in three ways. That is why the Portuguese choice is systematic but not universal.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Ela é bonita” — a quality
- “Ela está bonita” — right now
- “A sopa é boa; a sopa está boa.”

Twice through: “Ser: what it is. Estar: the condition it is in.”

Before you move on

What changes between *ela é bonita* and *ela está bonita*? (A defining quality versus a **current impression**.) Is *estar* automatically a mistake with *bonita*? (**No**; it says something different.) Which Romance languages keep the full two-verb choice? (**Portuguese and Spanish.**)

Chapter 17

Head and Hand

***By the end of this chapter:** I can name the head and the hand in Portuguese and explain the nasal vowel that swallowed the n of manus.*

Say a cabeça and a mão, pluralise to as mãos, and follow the n of manus dissolving between vowels, as it did in lua, boa and pão.

17.1 a cabeça — “the head”

Learn one body word and one reading rule together.

a cabeça — the head, feminine

Sounds you’ll need

The ç is a **cedilla**. It marks a *c* pronounced **s** before *a*, *o*, or *u*, where plain *c* would normally be hard **k**. So *cabeça* ends roughly “-essa,” not “-eka.”

The mark began as a tiny **z** under the letter: medieval scribes used ç as shorthand for *cz*. Treat that as a recognition hook; this track has not yet asked you to write the mark by hand.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Cabeça comes from Late Latin *capitia*, built from *caput*, “head.” Portuguese wore the word down in ordinary speech but kept the old root. A useful sentence is:

Dói-me a cabeça. — “My head hurts.” (European Portuguese)

In Brazilian Portuguese you may hear **Minha cabeça está doendo**. Both begin with the same feminine noun **a cabeça**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “a cabeça” — make ç an s
- “Dói-me a cabeça.”
- “cabeça ← caput”

Twice through: “A cabeça — feminine; ç sounds s.”

Before you move on

Say “the head.” (**A cabeça**.) What does the cedilla do? (Marks *c* as **s** before *a/o/u*.) What is the Latin root? (**Caput**.) Next: compare the head-words and find that root a second time in learned vocabulary.

17.2 cabeça / capital — one root, two arrivals

Cabeça kept Latin *caput*, “head.” Other languages used container words instead. That contrast makes the Portuguese survival visible.

language	“head”	older picture
Portuguese	cabeça	Latin <i>caput</i> , head
Spanish	<i>cabeza</i>	Latin <i>caput</i> , head
French	<i>tête</i>	Latin <i>testa</i> , pot
Italian	<i>testa</i>	Latin <i>testa</i> , pot
German	<i>Kopf</i>	Germanic “cup” word

French/Italian and German independently replaced “head” with a vessel. Iberian Romance kept *caput*. Portuguese still has **testa**, but narrowed it to “forehead” instead of the whole head.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The same *caput* later entered learned vocabulary again:

- **capital** — the head city or head sum;
- **capítulo** — a “little head” of a text;
- **capitão** — the head of a company.

Portuguese therefore holds a **doublet**: one word inherited through generations of speech (**cabeça**), another branch borrowed back from written Latin (**capital**, **capítulo**, **capitão**). One root can arrive twice and look different because each route changes it differently.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cabeça — inherited”
- “capital — re-borrowed”
- “tête/testa: pot; Kopf: cup”

Twice through: “Cabeça and capital — two routes from *caput*.”

Before you move on

Which two languages kept *caput* as their everyday head-word? (**Portuguese and Spanish**.) What did French, Italian, and German use instead? (**Container words**.) Why do *cabeça* and *capital* look different? (One is **inherited**; one is **re-borrowed**.) Next: the hand and the disappearing *n*.

17.3 a mão — “the hand”

Two things in one short word: a sound change that shaped half of Portuguese, and a gender that is two thousand years old.

You’ll want to know: The word

a mão — the hand. **Feminine**. Plural: as mãos.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin *manus* → Portuguese *mão*. The **-n-** vanished.

That is not a one-off. Portuguese systematically **dropped n between vowels**, nasalising the vowel in front of it. What happened next depends on the word: the nasality **stayed** where the result was a nasal diphthong, and **faded again** where it left a plain vowel. The **til** (~) marks the ones that kept it.

Latin	Portuguese	
<i>manus</i>	mão	hand — nasality kept
<i>lūna</i>	lua	moon — nasality faded
<i>bona</i>	boa	good (f.) — nasality faded
<i>pānis</i>	pão	bread — kept ; Chapter 11 told this one

Compare Spanish, which kept the **n** in all of them: *mano*, *luna*, *buena*, *pan*. This single change is a large part of why written Portuguese and Spanish look so similar and sound so different.

Say the pair aloud: *mano* ... *mão*. You can hear the *n* becoming the nasal.

Grammar Lens: Feminine, like Italian's

A **mão** is feminine — and so is Italian **la mano**, for the same reason. Latin *manus* belonged to the **fourth declension**, a class whose nouns ended in *-us* but could be feminine. The declension is long gone; the gender outlived it.

Portuguese is less startling about it than Italian, because *mão* doesn't end in a giveaway *-o*. But it is the same two-thousand-year-old fact underneath.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “a mão, as mãos”
- the change — “*manus* ... *mão*”

- the family — “lua, boa, pão — all lost an **n**”
- the contrast — “Spanish *mano*, Portuguese *mão*”

Before you move on

Say “the hand” and “the hands.” (*A mão / as mãos*.) What happened to the *n* of *manus*? (It **dissolved between vowels**, leaving a nasal vowel — which the **til** marks.) Name two other words that did the same. (*Lua* ← *lūna*, *boa* ← *bona*, *pão* — Ch. 11.) Did they all keep the nasality? (**No** — *mão* and *pão* did; *lua* and *boa* lost it again.) What did Spanish do? (**Kept the *n*** in all — *mano*, *luna*, *pan*.) Why is *mão* feminine? (Latin *manus* was **fourth-declension feminine** — the same reason Italian says *la mano*.) Next: the rest of the body.

Chapter 18

Verbs at the Core

By the end of this chapter: I can say I am, I have, I go, I come, I say, I see and I know in Portuguese, pick the right member of its two be-verbs and its two know-verbs, and name the English words each verb left behind.

The chapter's last lesson closes the set: after saber and conhecer the reader produces all nine first-person forms in one run - sou, estou, tenho, vou, venho, digo, vejo, sei, conheço - and re-derives the roots behind estar and ter.

18.1 ser / estar — one English verb, two Portuguese ones

English has one verb for “to be.” Portuguese answers it with two, and this lesson takes them as the single tool they are.

You'll want to know: The two-verb kit

ser — what it is	estar — how it is
sou, és, é, somos, são	estou, estás, está, estamos, estão
Sou médico. — I am a doctor.	Estou cansado. — I am tired.

One place Portuguese draws the line its own way: marriage. **Sou casado** — “I am married” — uses *ser*, because Portuguese files marital status under what you are. Spanish, the other Iberian daughter of Latin, standardly says *estoy casado* with its *estar* instead. The two languages inherited the same pair of verbs and did not put the same things on each side.

There is even a third verb in the neighbourhood: **ficar**, “to stay, to end up,” which is how Portuguese normally places a town or a building. **Lisboa fica em Portugal.**

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ser ← Latin *esse*, “to be.” English **is** and **am** are not borrowings from it; they are inherited relatives, the same ancient word arriving by the Germanic road. From *esse* Latin built *essentia* → **essence**, **essential**; its participle supplies **present** and **absent**; and the phrase *inter est*, “it is between, it matters,” hardened into **interest**.

estar ← Latin *stāre*, “to stand” → **stand**, **state**, **status**, **statue**, **station**, **stable**, **estate**, **circumstance**, **obstacle**, **distant**. Every one of them is about standing somewhere, which is exactly what *estar* still reports.

Flag the false friend: *estar* has nothing to do with English **stare**, which is a Germanic word for gazing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sou, és, é” · “estou, estás, está”
- “Sou médico; estou cansado.”
- “Sou casado” — Portuguese puts this on the *ser* side
- the standing family — “estar · state · status · estate”

Before you move on

Which verb names what something is, and which its condition? (***Ser***; ***estar***.) Which one does Portuguese use for “I am married”? (***Ser*** — *sou casado*.) What did *estar*’s Latin source mean? (“To **stand**” — *stāre*.) Name two English words from it. (**State**, **status**, **estate**, **circumstance**.) Next: the verb for having.

18.2 ter / haver — the verb that took the job

Portuguese has two candidates for “to have.” Only one of them does the everyday work; the other kept a single very useful shape.

You'll want to know: What each one does now

ter — the working verb	haver — what is left of it
tenho, tens, tem, temos, têm Tenho pão. — I have bread.	há , and little else Há pão. — There is bread.

Há never changes for number: *há um livro, há dois livros* — “there is,” “there are.” It also measures elapsed time: **há três anos** means “three years ago.”

Ter que plus an infinitive is how Portuguese states obligation: **Tenho que falar com ele** — “I have to speak with him.”

And here is the divergence worth naming. Portuguese builds its compound past on *ter*: **tenho falado**. Spanish keeps its *haber* for that job: *he hablado*. Two languages, the same two inherited verbs, opposite winners.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

haver ← Latin *habēre*, “to have, to hold.” Portuguese demoted the verb, but English is stuffed with its relatives: **habit** (*habitus*, “what one has on”), **inhabit**, **habitat**, **exhibit** (*ex-*, “to hold out”), **prohibit** (*pro-*, “to hold in front of”), **able** and **ability** (*habilis*, “easy to handle”) — and, through *dē* plus *habēre*, “to have from someone,” the words **debt**, **debit**, and **due**.

Now the trap. English **have** is *not* a descendant of *habēre*, however much the two look alike. It is Germanic, from an older root meaning “to seize” — the same root that gave Latin *capere* and so English **capture** and **capable**. A resemblance can be pure coincidence, and this is the famous one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tenho, tens, tem, temos, têm”
- “Tenho pão” · “Há pão”
- “Tenho que falar com ele”
- the *habēre* family — “habit · inhabit · able · debt”

Before you move on

Which verb carries everyday “have”? (**Ter.**) What is left of *haver*? (**Há** — “there is,” “there are,” and “ago.”) How do you say “I have to speak”? (**Tenho que falar.**) Which verb does Spanish use to build its compound past? (**Haber** — Portuguese uses *ter*.) Is English *have* related to *habēre*? (**No** — a coincidence.) Next: going.

18.3 **ir** — two letters, three ancestors

Portuguese’s verb for “to go” is two letters long, and no two of its rows resemble one another. There is a reason for that.

You’ll want to know: The forms, and the future they build

eu vou	nós vamos
tu vais	vocês/eles vão
ele/ela/você vai	

Its preterite is **fui, foste, foi, fomos, foram** — the row Chapter 16 showed *ir* borrowing wholesale from *ser*.

The everyday future runs through this verb: **ir** plus an infinitive.

Vou falar com ele. — “I am going to speak with him.”

English builds its own casual future the very same way, out of its own verb for going. And **vamos** on its own is “let’s go.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The infinitive **ir** comes from Latin *īre*, “to go.” The *vou* row comes from a different verb, *vādere*, “to advance.” The preterite comes from a third source entirely, the old perfect of *esse*.

From *īre* English holds a large family, all built by prefix: **exit** (*ex- itum*, “gone out”), **transit** (“gone across”), **initial** (*in- itium*, “a going in,” so a beginning), **itinerary**, **ambition** (*amb- īre*, “to go around” canvassing for votes), **perish** (*per- īre*, “to go all the way through”), and **obituary** (*ob- īre*, “to go to meet” death). Even the grammar word **preterite**, the tense of Chapter 15, is *praeter- itum*, “gone past.”

From *vādere*: **evade**, **invade**, **pervade** — and English **wade**, which is

not a borrowing at all but a Germanic cousin of the same ancient root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vou, vais, vai, vamos, vão”
- “Vou falar com ele”
- “Vamos!”
- the going family — “exit · transit · initial · ambition”

Before you move on

Give the present of *ir*. (**Vou, vais, vai, vamos, vão.**) How do you say “I am going to speak”? (***Vou falar.***) Which verb lends *ir* its preterite? (***Ser*** — *fui, foste, foi.*) Which Latin verb gives the infinitive? (***Īre.***) Name two English words from it. (**Exit, transit, initial, ambition, perish.**) Next: coming.

18.4 vir — coming, and the n that dissolved

The opposite of *ir* is **vir**, and it is short for exactly the reason *mão* is short.

You’ll want to know: The forms, and two traps

eu venho	nós vimos
tu vens	vocês/eles vêm
ele/ela/você vem	

Two things to watch:

- **vem** (“he comes”) against **vêm** (“they come”). The circumflex marks the plural and the sound barely moves — the same trick *tem* and *têm* play in Chapter 14. Portuguese lets an accent carry grammar.

- **venho** has the *-nh-*, Portuguese’s palatal *ny*, met already in *vinho* and *tenho*.

Useful on day one: **Vem cá.** — “Come here.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vir ← Latin *venīre*, “to come.” Take out the *-n-* between vowels and *venīre* collapses to *vir* — the same regular Portuguese change that turned *manus* into **mão** and *lūna* into **lua**. The *-nh-* forms are where the nasal survived instead of vanishing.

English kept the whole verb, prefix by prefix. A **venue** is “a coming”; an **advent** and an **adventure** are things coming *toward* you (*ad-*); to **convene** is to come together (*con-*), which gives **convenient** and **convention**; to **intervene** is to come between; to **prevent** was to come *before* (*prae-*); to **invent** is to come upon something. **Revenue** is what comes back, an **avenue** is the way a thing comes in, an **event** is what comes out (*ex-*), and a **souvenir** is a memory coming up from below (*sub-*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “venho, vens, vem, vimos, vêm”
- the accent pair — “ele **vem** · eles **vêm**”
- “Vem cá”
- the coming family — “venue · advent · convene · invent”

Before you move on

Give the present of *vir*. (**Venho, vens, vem, vimos, vêm.**) What separates *vem* from *vêm*? (The **circumflex** — singular against plural.) Why is the infinitive only three letters? (The **-n-** dissolved between vowels, as in *mão*.) Name two English words from *venīre*. (**Venue, advent, convene, prevent, event.**) Next: saying.

18.5 dizer — saying, and the verb that judges

Falar is to speak, in general. **Dizer** is to say a particular thing — and it hands you the most useful question a beginner owns.

You'll want to know: The forms, and the question

eu digo	nós dizemos
tu dizes	vocês/eles dizem
ele/ela/você diz	

The first person breaks ranks: **digo**, with a hard *g*, where every other form keeps a buzzing *z*. That swap is old and regular, and it recurs across this family of verbs.

Now the question. Chapter 2 gave you *como*, “how”:

Como se diz...? — “How does one say...?”

That one line will get you through a conversation you are not ready for. The past participle is **dito**, “said”, as in *dito e feito* — “said and done.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dizer ← Latin *dīcere*, “to say, to point out.” Its participle stem *dict-* is scattered through English: **dictate**, **dictation**, **dictionary**, **diction**, **dictator**; **verdict**, which is *vērū dictum*, “a true saying”; **predict** (“say beforehand”), **contradict** (“say against”), **edict**, **benediction** (“a good saying”), and **addict**, from *ad-dictus*, “spoken over to” someone.

The older sense, “to point,” survives in **indicate** and **index** — *in-dicāre* is to point *at* a thing.

And the prize: a Roman *iūdex* was the man who *speaks the law* — *iūs*, “law,” welded to *dīcere*. English took him as **judge**, and the family as **judicial**, **judgement**, and **prejudice**, a saying made in advance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “digo, dizes, diz, dizemos, dizem”

- “Como se diz...?”
- “dito e feito”
- the saying family — “dictate · verdict · edict · judge”

Before you move on

Give the present of *dizer*. (**Digo, dizes, diz, dizemos, dizem.**) Which form breaks the pattern? (**Digo**, with a hard *g*.) How do you ask how something is said? (**Como se diz...?**) What is a *verdict*, taken apart? (*Vērum dictum* — “**a true saying**”.) Where does **judge** come from? (*Iūs* plus *dīcere* — “**he who speaks the law**”.) Next: seeing.

18.6 ver — seeing, and a form that means two things

Ver, “to see,” is short for the same reason *vir* is: a consonant wore away in the middle. It also produces Portuguese’s most confusable single form.

You’ll want to know: The forms, and the collision

eu vejo	nós vemos
tu vês	vocês/eles veem
ele/ela/você vê	

Vejo takes a *j* that no other form has. Its completed past is **vi, viste, viu, vimos, viram**, and the participle is **visto**, “seen” — the same word as the noun **vista**, “a view,” which English borrowed whole.

Now the collision. **Vimos** is “we saw” here, and “we come” for *vir*. Nothing in the form tells them apart; the sentence around it does.

Vimos o mar. — “We saw the sea.” **Vimos de Lisboa.** — “We come from Lisbon.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ver ← Latin *vidēre*, “to see.” The *-d-* between vowels wore away, as it did in dozens of Portuguese verbs, leaving three letters.

English owns the rest of the verb: **vision**, **visible**, **visit**, and **video**, which is simply Latin for “I see.” With prefixes: **evident** (*ex-*, “seen out in the open”), **provide** and **providence** (*prō-*, “to see ahead”) — and **prudent**, which is nothing but *providens* worn down. Also **survey** and **supervise** (*super-*, “to see over”), **review**, **interview**, and **advise** with **advise**, from *ad vīsum*, “according to what has been seen.” Even **envy** is here: *in-vidēre*, “to look upon” someone with ill will.

One false friend. English **very** is *not* from this verb; it comes from *vērus*, “true” — the same *vērum* sitting inside **verdict**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vejo, vês, vê, vemos, veem”
- “vi, viste, viu, vimos, viram”
- the collision — “Vimos o mar · Vimos de Lisboa”
- the seeing family — “vision · evident · provide · survey”

Before you move on

Give the present of *ver*. (**Vejo, vês, vê, vemos, veem.**) What two things can *vimos* mean? (“**We saw**” and “**we come**”.) What happened to *vidēre*’s **-d-**? (It **wore away between vowels**.) Which English word is *providens* worn down? (**Prudent.**) Is *very* part of this family? (**No** — that is *vērus*, “true”.) Next: knowing, in two flavours.

18.7 saber / conhecer — two ways to know

This chapter opened with one English verb answered by two Portuguese ones. It closes with the second such pair — and this one hides a flavour.

You'll want to know: Which knowing is which

saber — facts and skills	conhecer — people and places
sei, sabes, sabe, sabemos, sabem	conheço, conheces, conhece, conhecem
Sei a resposta. — I know the answer.	Conheço o Pedro. — I know Pedro.
Sei nadar. — I know how to swim.	Conheço Lisboa. — I know Lisbon.

Saber is knowing *that* something is so, or knowing *how* to do a thing. **Conhecer** is being acquainted with a person, a city, a book. French splits the idea the same way, with *savoir* and *connaître*; English merged the two and lost the distinction entirely.

Sei is worth its own breath: it is irregular, it is short, and **não sei**, “I don’t know,” is the sentence you will need first.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

saber ← Latin *sapere*, which meant “**to taste**” long before it meant “to have good taste, to be wise.” Portuguese kept both jobs in the one verb: **sabe bem** means “it tastes good,” and **sabor** is “flavour.” English split the halves between two borrowings — the taste half as **savour** and **savoury**, the wisdom half as **sapient**, the word inside *Homo sapiens*, and **sage**. Something **insipid** is *in-sapidus*, “without taste.”

conhecer ← Latin *cognōscere*, which is *co-* (“thoroughly”) plus *gnōscere* (“to get to know”). English holds the compound as **cognition**, **recognise**, **incognito**, **notice**, **notion**, and, through French, **connoisseur** — the very same verb. That second piece is also the root English **know** itself grew from, so *conhecer* and *know* are distant relatives after all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sei, sabes, sabe” · “conheço, conheces, conhece”
- “Não sei” · “Conheço Lisboa”
- the whole chapter, first person — “sou, estou, tenho, vou, venho, digo, vejo, sei, conheço”
- the taste still inside the verb — “sabe bem”

Before you move on

Which verb knows a fact, and which knows a person? (**Saber**; **conhecer**.) Say “I don’t know.” (**Não sei**.) What did *sapere* mean first? (“**To taste**” — still live in *sabe bem*.) Now the nine of this chapter, in the *eu* form. (**Sou, estou, tenho, vou, venho, digo, vejo, sei, conheço**.) And their roots: which one came from “to stand”? (**Estar**, from *stāre*.) Which from “to hold”? (**Ter**, from *tenēre*.)

Chapter 19

Verbs of the Mind

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I think, understand, read and write in Portuguese, produce the broken row ler shares with ver, and name the English words each of the four verbs left behind.

The chapter's last lesson closes the set: after escrever the reader produces all four first-person forms in one run - penso, entendo, leio, escrevo - names escrito as the Latin scriptum, and re-derives the propped-up e- that turned scribere into escrever and stare into estar.

19.1 pensar — thinking, and the scales it came from

The last chapter gave you the nine verbs Portuguese cannot do without. This one adds four that all happen inside your head — and the first of them weighs things.

You'll want to know: A plain -ar verb, and the small word after it

eu **penso**

tu **pensas**

ele/ela/você **pensa**

nós **pensamos**

vocês/eles **pensam**

No surprises in the endings: *pensar* runs exactly like *falar*, the first verb you met. What has to be learned is the word that follows it. Portuguese thinks **in** a thing, not about it:

Penso em ti. — “I think of you.” **Penso que sim.** — “I think so.”

Pensar em for whatever you have in mind; *pensar que* for an opinion. In everyday Brazilian speech the opinion verb is more often **achar** — *acho que sim* — a verb whose plain meaning is “to find.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pensar ← Latin *pēnsāre*, “to weigh out carefully,” built on *pendere*, “to hang” — because a Roman weighed a thing by **hanging** it from a balance. To think, on that picture, is to put two things on the scales. English owns the whole family. From the weighing half: **pensive**, and **ponder**, which is *ponderāre* from *pondus*, a weight. From the paying half — coins were weighed out before they were counted — **pension**, **compensate**, **dispense**, **expense** and **expend**, **stipend**, **recompense**. And from the hanging half: **pendulum**, **pendant**, **pending**, **depend** (“to hang from”), **suspend**, **append**, **impending**. Spanish, another daughter of Latin, put the same verb on its coin: a *peso* is a weight. **achar** has its own history — Latin *afflāre*, “to breathe upon,” a hunter’s word for catching a scent on the air. So the everyday Brazilian “I think” is really “I find.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “penso, pensas, pensa, pensamos, pensam”
- “Penso em ti” · “Penso que sim”
- knowing beside thinking — “sei” · “penso”
- the weighing family — “pensive · ponder · pension · pendulum”

Before you move on

Give the present of *pensar*. (**Penso, pensas, pensa, pensamos, pensam.**) Which small word follows it when someone is on your mind? (**Em** — *penso em ti*.) What did *pēnsāre* mean? (“To **weigh out**.”) So what is a *pendulum* doing? (**Hanging** — from *pendere*.) And which verb from the last chapter says “I know a fact”? (**Sei**.)

Next: understanding.

19.2 entender / compreender — reaching for it, or grabbing all of it

Weighing a thought was the last lesson. This one is the moment the thought lands — and Portuguese has two verbs for it, built on two pictures.

You'll want to know: The everyday one, and the fuller one

entender — every day	compreender — a shade deeper
entendo, entendes, entende, entendemos, entendem	compreendo, compreendes, compreende, compreendem
Não entendo. — I don't understand.	Compreendo a situação. — I grasp the situation.

Both are ordinary *-er* verbs, and in most sentences either one is correct. **Entender** is the workhorse: *Não entendo*, *Entendeu?*, *Entendes?* **Compreender** carries more weight — understanding a thing through, or taking someone's side of it — and it does a second job English gives to another word entirely: *o preço compreende tudo*, “the price **includes** everything.”

If only one sticks, make it *entender*. **Não entendo** may be the single most useful sentence a beginner owns.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

entender ← Latin *intendere*: *in-* (“toward”) plus *tendere* (“to stretch”). To understand was to **stretch your attention toward** a thing. English keeps the family whole: **intend** and **intention** — the same verb, meaning barely moved — plus **intense**, **tend**, **tendency**, **tension**, **extend**, **pretend** (“to stretch in front”), **contend**, **attend**, **portend**. And the things that literally stretch: a **tent**, a **tendon**. **compreender** ← *comprehendere*: *com-* (“together”) plus *prehendere* (“to seize”). Not reaching this time but **grabbing**, and grabbing all of it at once — **comprehend**, **comprehensive**, **apprehend**, **prehensile**. Worn down through French, that same *prehendere* also gives **prison** (a “seizing”), **prize**, **enterprise**, and **surprise**, which is *super-prehendere*, “seized from above.”

Flag the false friend: English **understand** belongs to neither family. It is Germanic, and its own picture is standing close among things.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “entendo, entendes, entende, entendemos, entendem”
- “Não entendo” · “Compreendo a situação”
- thinking, then understanding — “penso” · “entendo”
- the stretching family — “intend · intense · extend · tendon”

Before you move on

Say “I don’t understand.” (*Não entendo.*) Which of the two also means “to include”? (*Compreender.*) What does *tendere* mean, and what is *in-tendere* doing? (“To **stretch**”; stretching **toward** a thing.) Taken apart, what is a *surprise*? (*Super-prehendere* — “**seized from above**”.) Is English *understand* a relative? (**No** — it is Germanic.) And *pensar*’s root meaning? (“To **weigh**”.) Next: reading.

19.3 ler — a verb that gathers, worn down to three letters

Ver, “to see,” was three letters and irregular. **Ler**, “to read,” is three letters and irregular in exactly the same way — and for the same reason.

You’ll want to know: **leio**, **lê**, **leem**

eu leio	nós leemos
tu lê s	vocês/eles leem
ele/ela/você lê	

Say them slowly. **Leio** has grown a *y*-glide in the middle. **Lê** is a single vowel held up by a circumflex. **Leem** is two *e*’s in a row, and Portuguese pronounces both of them. **Não leio muito** — “I don’t read much.”

This is not random damage. It is the very row *ver* uses — *veja, vês, vê, vemos, veem* — and the one *crer*, “to believe,” uses too: *creio, crês, cré, cremos, creem*. Learn the row once and three verbs come with it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ler ← Latin *legere*, whose first meaning was not reading at all. It was “**to gather, to pick, to choose.**” Reading was the metaphor — gathering letters up with the eye — and the metaphor won.

The shrinking is regular, and you have already met it. Latin *legere* lost its *-g-* between vowels, exactly as *manus* lost its *-n-* to give *mão*; that leaves *leer*, whose two vowels then collapse into one. **Ler** is what is left, and the circumflex on *lê* is the record of the collapse.

English took both halves of *legere*. The gathering half: **collect, select, elect** (“to pick out”), **intellect** (“to choose between”), **diligent, neglect** (“not to gather up”), and **elegant**, which first meant choosy. The reading half: **legible, lecture, lectern, legend** (“things to be read”), and — through French *leçon* — the word **lesson** itself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “leio, lê, lê, lemos, leem”
- the same row for seeing — “veja, vês, vê, vemos, veem”
- “Não leio muito” · “Não entendo”
- the gathering family — “collect · select · elect · legend”

Before you move on

Give the present of *ler*, then the same row for *ver*. (**Leio, lê, lê, lemos, leem; vejo, vês, vê, vemos, veem.**) What did *legere* mean before it meant “to read”, and what went missing on the way to *ler*? (“To **gather**, to pick, to choose”; the *-g-*, between vowels, as in *mão* from *manus*.) Where is that root in English? (**Legible, lecture, legend, lesson.**) Next: writing.

19.4 **escrever** — scratching, and the e- that props up an s

Reading came last; writing is its partner. And this verb carries a spelling rule that will unlock dozens of other Portuguese words for you.

You’ll want to know: The forms, and a participle you already own

eu escrevo	nós escrevemos
tu escreves	vocês/eles escrevem
ele/ela/você escreve	

A plain *-er* verb, endings identical to *entender*. The irregularity sits elsewhere: the past participle is **escrito**, never *escrevido*.

Já escrevi a carta. — “I already wrote the letter.” **Está escrito.** — “It is written.”

Escrito is the Latin *scriptum* barely touched — which means **escrito** and English **script** are one word arriving twice.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

escrever ← Latin *scr̄ibere*, “to scratch, to incise,” because writing began as cutting marks into wax, clay, or bark. Its participle stem *script-* is among the most productive things English ever borrowed: **scribe**, **scribble**, **script**, **scripture**, **describe** and **description**, **prescribe**, **subscribe**, **transcribe**, **inscribe**, **ascribe**, **conscript**, **circumscribe**, **postscript** — and **manuscript**, which is *manus* plus *scriptum*, “written by the hand.” Old English borrowed the verb early and wore it down to **shrive** and **shrift**, the confession words behind *Shrove Tuesday*. Now the rule. Latin *scr̄ibere* opens with *sc-*, and Iberian mouths would not start a word that way, so they propped a vowel in front of it. It happened without exception:

- *scr̄ibere* → **escrever**
- *schola* → **escola** (“school”)
- *stāre* → **estar** — the being-verb you already have

- *spērāre* → **esperar** (“to wait, to hope”)
- *spatium* → **espaço**

So when a Portuguese word opens with **es-** and the rest of it resembles an English word missing its *e*, it usually is one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “escrevo, escreves, escreve, escrevemos, escrevem”
- “Já escrevi a carta” · “Está escrito”
- the chapter’s four, first person — “penso, entendo, leio, escrevo”
- the propped-up *e* — “escrever · escola · estar · esperar”

Before you move on

Give the present of *escrever*. (**Escrevo, escreves, escreve, escrevemos, escrevem.**) What is its past participle? (**Escrito** — Latin *scriptum*.) What did *scribere* mean literally? (“To **scratch**”.) Why *escola* and not *scola*? (Iberian Romance **propped an e-** in front of *sc-*, *sp-*, *st-*.) Which verb of being got the same treatment? (**Estar**, from *stāre*.) Now the four verbs of this chapter, in the *eu* form. (**Penso, entendo, leio, escrevo.**) Next: taking.

Chapter 20

Taking, Asking, Helping, Liking

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I take, ask, help and like in Portuguese, choose between its two verbs for taking, and keep *de* attached to *gostar*.

*The chapter's last lesson closes the set: after *gostar de* the reader produces the eight first-person forms of both verb chapters in one run - *penso, entendo, leio, escrevo, pego, pergunto, ajudo, gosto* - explains why the *de* cannot be dropped, and ties *gostar* back to *saber* as the second Portuguese verb that stopped meaning to taste.*

20.1 tomar / pegar — the two takings

English “take” does everything: take a bus, take a coffee, take a book, take a bath. Portuguese splits the work in two, and the line it draws is easy to feel.

You'll want to know: Into your hand, or into you

pegar — grasp, catch, grab	tomar — consume, take in
pego, pegas, pega, pegamos, pegam	tomo, tomas, toma, tomamos, tomam
Pego o livro. — I pick up the book.	Tomo um café. — I have a coffee.
Pegar um táxi. — To catch a taxi.	Tomar banho. — To take a bath.

The rule of thumb: if the thing ends up **in your hand**, it is *pegar*; if it ends up **inside you** — a drink, a medicine, a bath, a decision — it is *tomar*. Both are ordinary *-ar* verbs, so nothing in the endings is new.

One variety note: Portugal puts an *em* behind *pegar*, *pego no livro*, where Brazil says *pego o livro*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pegar ← Latin *picāre*, “to coat with pitch,” from *pīx*, *pīcis* — the black tar that sealed a ship’s hull. To *pegar* a thing was to make it **stick** to you, and Portuguese still uses that sense straight: **pegajoso** is “sticky,” and *a porta não pega* is a door that will not catch. English took the same *pīx* as **pitch** — the tar, not the musical note, which is a different word altogether.

tomar is the honest gap in this chapter. Nobody has pinned its Latin source down: one proposal is *autumāre*, “to assert,” worn away to nothing, another an unrecorded *tumāre*, and neither is settled. A book that dressed a guess up as a root would be handing you a memory hook with nothing behind it. What is certain is that *tomar* is old and Iberian — Spanish carries the same verb with the same spread of senses, and no other Romance language has it at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pego, pegas, pega” · “tomo, tomas, toma”
- “Tomo um café” · “Pegar um táxi”
- having and taking — “tenho um livro” · “pego o livro”
- the sticking family — “pegar · pegajoso · pitch”

Before you move on

Which verb takes a coffee, and which takes a book? (**Tomar**; **pegar**.) Say “I have a coffee.” (**Tomo um café**.) What did *picāre* mean, and what is *tomar*’s root? (To coat with **pitch**, so *pegar* is “to make stick”; *tomar*’s is **unknown** — disputed, and named as such.) Now “I have” and “I write”. (**Tenho**; **escrevo**.) Next: asking.

20.2 perguntar — asking, and the pole in the water

You have *dizer*, “to say.” Here is the verb that runs the other way — and a second one beside it, because Portuguese asks a

question and asks **for** a thing with different verbs.

You'll want to know: **perguntar**, and its neighbour **pedir**

eu pergunto	nós perguntamos
tu perguntas	vocês/eles perguntam
ele/ela/você pergunta	

An ordinary *-ar* verb, with its noun beside it: **uma pergunta**, “a question.”

Posso fazer uma pergunta? — “May I ask a question?” (Portuguese *makes* one.) **Perguntei pelo João.** — “I asked after João.”

Now the neighbour. **Pedir** is “to ask **for**” — to request, to order. *Pergunto a hora* is asking what the time is; *peço um café* is ordering one. English says “ask” for both and loses the difference; Portuguese never mixes them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

perguntar ← Latin *percontārī*, “to inquire” — and the picture inside it is worth the whole lesson. It is *per-*, “through,” plus *contus*, “a punting pole.” To *percontārī* was to **push a pole through the water to find the bottom**. Asking is sounding the depth of something you cannot see into.

The road to *perguntar* runs through a hardened *c* and a wandering *r*: *percontare* → *pergontar* → *perguntar*. Spanish, another daughter of Latin, moved that *r* one step further forward and says *preguntar*.

A warning about the cousins, because honesty beats a long list: this root left English almost nothing. *Per-* is everywhere — **perceive, perform, permit** — but *contus*, borrowed into Latin from Greek *kontos*, survives only in technical corners.

pedir does better: Latin *petere*, “to seek, to make for,” gives **petition, appetite, compete, impetus, perpetual**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pergunto, perguntas, pergunta, perguntamos, perguntam”

- “Posso fazer uma pergunta?”
- saying against asking — “digo” · “pergunto”
- the asking-for family — “petition · appetite · compete · impetus”

Before you move on

Which verb asks a question, and which asks for a coffee? (*Perguntar*; *pedir*.) Say “May I ask a question.” (*Posso fazer uma pergunta?*) What is a *contus*, and what is asking on the Latin picture? (A **pole**; **probing the bottom** of something you cannot see into.) Where does *pedir* come from, and what court word did *dizer* leave English? (*Petere*, “to seek” → **appetite**, **compete**; **verdict**.) Next: helping.

20.3 ajudar — helping, and the j that used to be an i

Asking came last. This is the verb for when the answer is yes.

You’ll want to know: The forms, and the sentence to keep ready

eu ajudo	nós ajudamos
tu ajudas	vocês/eles ajudam
ele/ela/você ajuda	

An ordinary *-ar* verb. The sound to get right is the **j**, which is not the *j* of English *jam*: it is the soft buzz in the middle of *measure* and *pleasure*. Say *a-ZHU-dar*.

Pode ajudar-me? — “Can you help me?” **Preciso de ajuda.**
— “I need help.”

Where that little *me* stands is one of the live differences between the two great varieties: Portugal hangs it on the end with a hyphen, *ajudar-me*; Brazil puts it in front, *me ajudar*. Both are standard where they are spoken. For real trouble, though, the word is not this verb at all — it is **Socorro!**

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ajudar ← Latin *adiūtāre*, the repeating form of *adiuvāre*: *ad-* (“to-ward”) plus *iuvāre* (“to help, to gladden”). The picture is of coming toward someone, over and over.

Latin *i* before a vowel was said like English *y*, and that *y* is what hardened into the Portuguese *j*: *adiūtāre* → *aiudar* → **ajudar**. The same change gave *hoje*, *já*, and *janeiro*, the month you already know.

English took the verb by two roads. Through French, where it wore down to *aider*, it arrived as **aid**, an **aide**, and **first aid**. Straight from Latin it also took **adjutant**, the officer who assists, and **adjuvant**, a medicine that helps another medicine work.

Four sisters, one verb: Portuguese *ajudar*, Spanish *ayudar*, French *aider*, Italian *aiutare* — all four *adiūtāre*, each worn down its own way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ajudo, ajudas, ajuda, ajudamos, ajudam”
- “Pode ajudar-me?” · “Preciso de ajuda”
- asking, then helping — “pergunto” · “ajudo”
- the soft j — “ajudar · hoje · já · janeiro”

Before you move on

Give the present of *ajudar*, and say how that *j* sounds. (**Ajudo, ajudas, ajuda, ajudamos, ajudam**; like the *s* in **measure**.) Ask someone for help. (*Pode ajudar-me?*) What is *adiūtāre* built from, and what did English take from it? (*Ad-*, “toward,” plus *iuvāre*, “**to help**”; **aid**, **aide**, **adjutant**, **adjuvant**.) And *contus*, in *perguntar*? (A **pole**.) Next: liking — and the one small word Portuguese insists on.

20.4 gostar de — liking, which in Portuguese is tasting

The last verb of the chapter, and the one that catches everybody out. In Portuguese you do not like a thing — you like **of** it.

You'll want to know: The forms

eu **gosto**
 tu **gostas**
 ele/ela/você **gosta**

nós **gostamos**
 vocês/eles **gostam**

An ordinary *-ar* verb. Everything hard about *gostar* is the word after it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gostar ← Latin *gustāre*, “to taste” — not to like, but to put a thing in your mouth and judge it. English took it as **gusto**, **gustatory**, a **degustation**, and its opposite **disgust**: *dis-* plus *gustus*, a bad taste. So Portuguese holds **two** verbs that once meant “to taste.” *Sapere* became *saber*, “to know,” and still tastes in *sabe bem*; *gustāre* became *gostar*. One language, one metaphor, taken twice.

Grammar Lens: why the *de* is not optional

Latin never said “taste a thing.” It said **taste of a thing** — *gustāre de* — because a sip comes **from** what is in front of you, not the whole of it. Portuguese inherited the preposition along with the verb:

Gosto de café. — “I like coffee.” (Word for word: “I taste of coffee.”) **Gosto de você.** — “I like you.” (Word for word: “I like of you.”) **Gostamos muito de Lisboa.** — “We like Lisbon very much.”

The *de* is fixed; dropping it is the mistake that marks a beginner fastest. And *de* fuses with any article it meets — *de + o = do*, *de + a = da*, *de + os = dos*, *de + as = das* — so “I like the wine” is *gosto do vinho*, never *de o vinho*.

Spanish, the other Iberian daughter of Latin, escaped the same problem the opposite way: it flips the sentence so the thing liked becomes the subject — *me gusta el café*, “the coffee pleases me.” Portuguese keeps **you** as the subject and hangs the preposition on the object instead. For the stronger feeling: **adorar**, which needs no *de* (*adoro café*), and **amar**, kept mostly for people.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gosto, gostas, gosta, gostamos, gostam”
- “Gosto de café” · “Gosto de você” · “Gosto do vinho”
- the two tasting verbs — “sabe bem” · “gosto de”
- both verb chapters, first person — “penso, entendo, leio, escrevo, pego, pergunto, ajudo, gosto”

Before you move on

Say “I like coffee,” then “I like the wine.” (*Gosto de café; gosto do vinho*, since *de + o* fuses to *do*.) Why the *de*, what did *gustāre* mean, and which earlier verb has the same story? (You take a taste **of** a thing; “to **taste**”; *saber*, from *sapere*.) Now the eight of these two chapters, in the *eu* form. (**Penso, entendo, leio, escrevo, pego, pergunto, ajudo, gosto.**)

Portuguese pronunciation — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — each lesson gives the sounds its word needs. This page gathers them. Portuguese spelling is fairly regular, but its **nasal vowels** and soft consonants surprise English speakers.

The traps for an English speaker

- **Nasal vowels.** A vowel before *m/n* (or under a tilde) is sent through the nose: *bom* = *bõ*, *sim* (“yes”) = *sĩ*, *pão* (“bread”) = *pãw*. English has no exact match — hum the vowel.
- **Vowels reduce.** Unstressed *e* often vanishes to a whisper or *i*; final *o* sounds like *u* (*obrigado* ≈ “oh-bree-GAH-doo”).
- **s** between vowels = *z*; at the end of a syllable it is often *sh* (European) or *s* (most of Brazil).
- **lh** = the *lli* of *million*; **nh** = the *ny* of *canyon*; **ç** = *s*.
- **r** at the start of a word, or **rr**, is a strong guttural (like a Scottish/French *r* or even an *h*); a single *r* between vowels is a light tap.

Stress

Usually the second-to-last syllable; a written accent (*á*, *â*, *ã*) marks any exception (*olá*, *café*, *avô*).

Portuguese in the Romance family

Portuguese, Spanish, French, and Italian are all worn-down Latin. Portuguese often eroded the most (the article *ille* → *o*); it turned Latin *-ct-* into *-it-* (*noite*, like French *nuit*); and it kept *dies* close (*o dia*, like Spanish *día*). The lessons draw these contrasts as they arise.